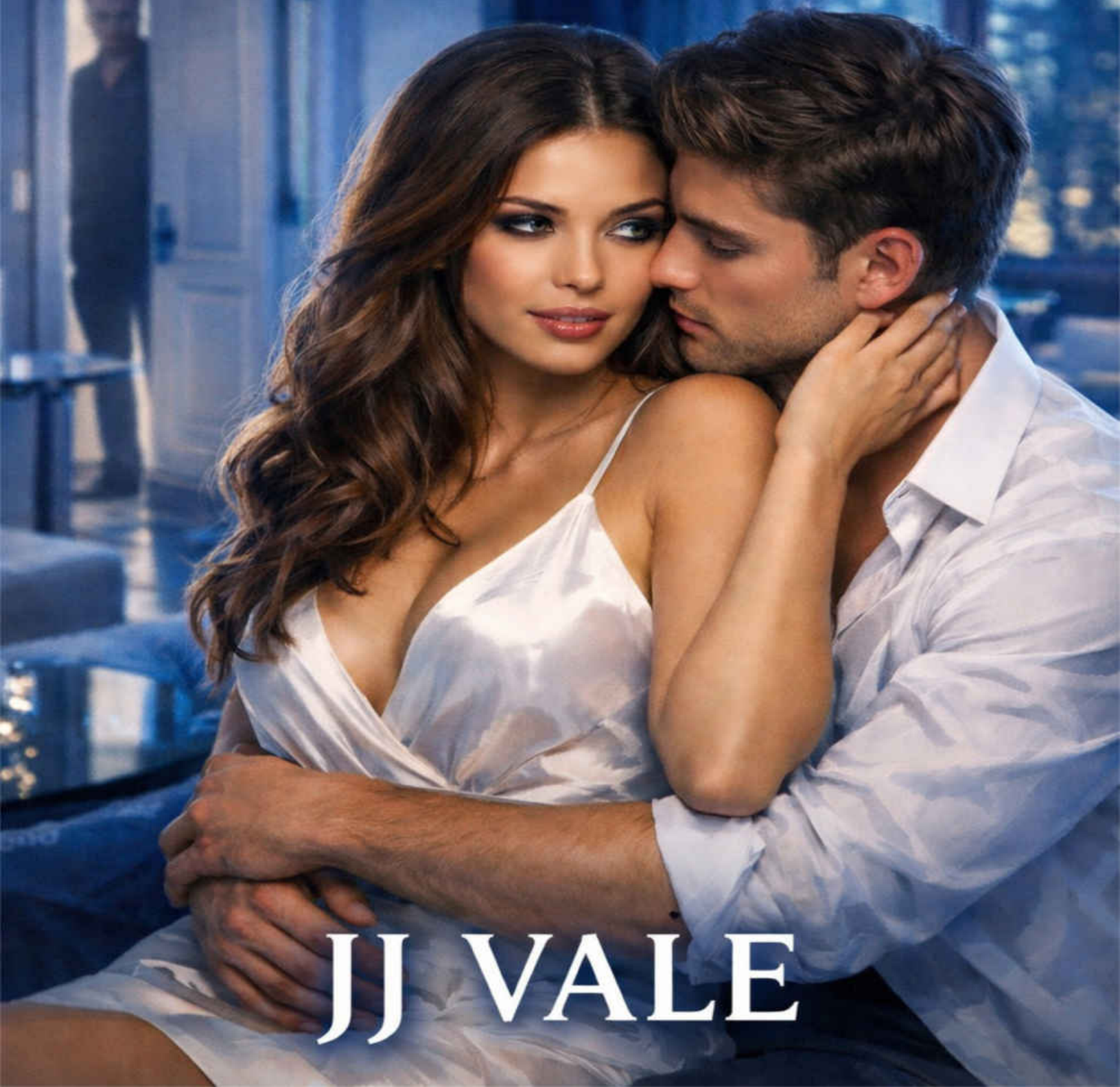


THEY MADE ME WATCH

He knew I couldn't stop her



JJ VALE

They Made Me Watch
He knew I couldn't stop her

JJ Vale

PMI

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Chapter 1

The night started so normal that I nearly let my guard drop.

Mara was already in the kitchen when I got home, barefoot on the tile, hair pinned up with a clip. Two cutting boards sat on the counter, one lined with limes, the other carrying a bite of garlic and something sharper. Low music played some vibes. She moved with that quiet certainty that made a room feel arranged around her without any visible effort.

“You’re late,” she said, still looking down.

“I’m not late. I’m exactly on time,” I said, setting the bags down.

She turned, eyes flicking to the bottles, and her mouth tightened into that restrained curve she used when she was pleased and refused to admit it. “That’s tequila.”

“You said tequila.”

“I said a lot of things.” She stepped in for a kiss that landed like a stamp, her mouth quick and cool, her hand briefly at the back of my neck as if to remind me who could pull me in and who could let go first. “Did you text Owen?”

I paused with my jacket half off. “About what?”

“About coming,” she said, like my question was the odd part.

I finished taking off my jacket and folded it slowly over the chair. “You invited him?”

She gave a small shrug. “He asked what we were doing. I told him we were having people over. You said you wanted to host more.”

I didn’t like how cleanly she set that down, like I’d signed something without reading the fine print.

“Owen’s not ‘people,’” I said.

“He’s your friend,” she said. “He’s funny. He brings joy.”

I watched her reach past me for the limes, her forearm brushing my chest with intent that wasn’t accidental. Her nails were painted a dark red that looked deliberate against the pale green wedges.

“He’s also . . .” I started.

She cut me off with a look. “Don’t.”

“Don’t what?”

“Don’t turn it into something,” she said, still light, eyes sharper now. “It’s game night. Your coworkers are coming. Nina’s coming. It’s loud. It’s casual.”

“Right,” I said, because Mara said casual the way other people said solved, with that full stop.

I set the tequila down. “Did he say yes?”

Her smile flashed. “He said, ‘Obviously.’”

Of course he did.

Owen took up space even when he wasn’t in the room. He moved like he didn’t negotiate for anything. Certainty sat on him the way some men wore scent, close and persistent. Mara acted like he didn’t matter to her, which meant I noticed him more.

She kept cutting limes into neat wedges, fingers quick, and only looked up when she realized I hadn’t moved.

“What?” she asked.

“Nothing.”

She tilted her head, studying me like she’d already filed me under predictable. “You’re doing that thing.”

“What thing?”

“Thinking you can read me,” she said, voice dropping a fraction. “You can’t.”

I swallowed. “I can read you.”

Mara laughed softly, almost kindly, and leaned in until her mouth hovered near my ear, close enough that the heat of her breath did more than the words. “Tonight,” she murmured, “you’re going to try.”

Then she stepped away as if she hadn’t just pressed a thumb into the soft part of my attention and left it there.

Her phone buzzed on the counter. Owen’s name lit the screen.

I saw it before she turned it, and she didn’t bother to hide it.

On the screen: “On my way.”

She set the phone down again and went back to the limes.

A moment later it buzzed again. This time she let it sit while she rinsed her hands, dried them with slow care, then glanced at the screen like she’d remembered it mid-thought.

“Parking. Be up in two.”

She turned the phone facedown.

“He’s early,” I said, keeping my tone flat.

“It’s Owen,” she said, reaching for the shaker. “He treats time like a suggestion.”

I started to say something and didn’t. I went into the living room and shifted chairs like spacing could fix what was already moving under my skin. From the kitchen, ice rattled in the shaker, hard and steady, and the sound irritated me because it was controlled. Mara always got controlled when she wanted to feel in charge of the room.

The buzzer went off.

My head snapped up before I could stop it, and I slowed myself on the way to the intercom as if pace could cover reaction. “Yeah?”

“Owen,” came the voice, amused, like he’d already decided he was welcome. “Let me up.”

I hit the button. The lock clicked.

Mara didn’t hurry. She kept moving through the drink like she wanted me to notice she had no reason to rush.

When Owen knocked, I opened the door with my best host face, polite and neutral, and I hated that I cared enough to perform.

He walked in carrying two bottles of wine. His coat was dark, hair damp from the rain, and whatever he wore on his skin smelled expensive without being loud about it. He looked past me into the apartment, then his attention found Mara, and his expression shifted into something easy.

“Mara,” he said, like her name belonged to him.

“Owen,” she said, and she didn’t step toward him, making him cross the last distance.

He did. He leaned in for her cheek, paused a fraction close enough that I saw it and couldn’t prove it, then kissed the air beside her skin like restraint was a choice he could take credit for.

“Smells good,” he said.

“Tequila,” she said. “You’re a wine guy.”

“Tonight I’m whatever you need,” he said lightly, then turned that same ease on me. “Hey, man.”

I stepped forward and offered my hand. He took it with a firm grip that lasted a beat too long, his eyes moving over my face like he expected to find something. He always wanted a tell.

“How’s the new project?” he asked.

I blinked. “Fine. Busy.”

“Busy is good,” he said, like he was handing out approval.

Mara set three glasses on the counter. “You two can do the whole dominance thing later. Drink.”

My mouth tightened into something that almost counted as a smile. Owen laughed like he liked being corrected, which was another kind of control.

Mara slid a glass to me first. My fingers brushed hers and the contact carried a message I’d been trying not to need: remember where you are, remember what you came home to. Her eyes stayed on my hand for half a second, then lifted to my face, calm and unreadable.

Then she handed one to Owen.

His fingers grazed her wrist in a way that could be dismissed as accidental if you wanted to live inside convenient explanations. He didn’t let go right away. Mara didn’t pull back. The space between what happened and what could be claimed opened wide enough to fall into.

Nina arrived ten minutes later with a grocery bag of snacks and her usual practical brightness. She took one look at the three of us clustered in the kitchen and raised her eyebrows.

“Okay,” she said, hanging up her coat. “Either you’re hosting a normal game night, or you’re about to tell me you joined a cult.”

“It’s normal,” I said.

“Normal,” Mara added a half beat later, and Owen’s grin sharpened like he’d scored something small.

More people filtered in: coworkers I barely tolerated outside Slack, two of Mara’s friends from yoga, and a guy named Ben who talked too loudly and apologized for it every time, which only guaranteed he did it again. The apartment filled in increments until no one had enough space to stand alone without being absorbed into someone else’s circle.

Owen settled into the room as if placement was inevitable. He didn’t bulldoze conversation. He didn’t need to. He made small observations that landed cleanly, laughed at the right moments, and listened in a way that made people offer more than they meant to. By the time cards came out, attention kept tipping toward him, one minor shift at a time.

I tried to host. I poured drinks, explained rules, checked on people, smiled on cue, but my focus kept snapping back to Mara like a reflex I couldn’t train out. She noticed, and instead of easing me, she loosened into the evening like she didn’t have to account for anyone. She sat on the arm of the couch, legs tucked up, sweater slipping off one shoulder, the line of

skin there not an accident. When she laughed she touched people lightly, fingers on a forearm or a knee, brief enough to claim nothing and frequent enough to establish a rhythm.

Owen stayed close, not pressed against her, just placed where her attention would pass by him on its way anywhere else. When someone asked how they all knew each other, Mara said, “College. Eli and Owen were inseparable,” and Owen added, “Still are, he just pretends he’s too busy for me,” and I gave a smile that didn’t reach anywhere useful. The comment was harmless on its face and pointed underneath, and I couldn’t object without sounding small.

Halfway through the first game, Mara’s phone lit up on the coffee table where she’d left it face up. My eyes went to it before I could stop myself. I didn’t touch it. Touching it would’ve been a confession. I looked at Mara to see if she’d seen me look.

The preview read: “Bathroom. Two minutes.”

I couldn’t see the name because the banner hid it, and uncertainty hit harder than certainty would have. Mara picked up the phone, thumb hovering as if she was deciding whether to be discreet, then smiled at the screen, small and private, and set it back down without replying.

Owen’s gaze flicked to the phone and then to Mara’s face. Something passed between them that was quick enough to deny and clear enough to sting. I caught it because I was watching for it, and the watching made everything worse, because the room was too loud for questions and too full for confrontation. With six conversations overlapping and someone arguing about rules, all I could do was sit there and turn glances into evidence.

A few minutes later Mara stood with her drink in hand and the easy excuse of the kitchen. “I’m making another round,” she said, and it came out like generosity, like hosting, like something no one could challenge. Owen shifted as if he might follow, then stayed put, eyes on the cards, smile still in place. I offered to help and Mara waved me off without looking at me.

“You’ll just get in the way,” she said.

People laughed like it was playful. I laughed with them, then let my face go tight the moment nobody paid attention.

In the kitchen, Mara moved with practiced familiarity, measuring nothing, counting pours in her head. She kept her phone near the cutting

board. The screen lit again, and this time the banner stayed up long enough for her to see the sender.

Owen.

I wasn't in there with her long enough to see the exact expression, but I could picture the posture. She didn't move fast. She didn't owe speed to anything. She treated the choice to respond like a choice she never had to justify. She didn't reply. She set the phone down angled toward herself and shook the drinks as if the sound covered intention.

When she carried the tray back to the living room, Owen looked up immediately, eyes finding her before the glasses. He waited until she set everything down, until her wrist passed close, then leaned in low enough that nobody else could catch words over the noise.

"I'm getting killed in here," he murmured, light, with familiarity underneath.

Mara replied just as quietly, face neutral. "Then stop trying to win."

His smile shifted. "Is that what you think I'm doing?"

Mara didn't answer in words. She lifted a glass and moved away, giving the room the version of her that looked busy and unconcerned. Owen's eyes followed her long enough that I registered it even while Ben talked too loud beside me about his new car. I saw Owen watching Mara and Mara behaving as if she didn't notice him, and it was the performance that made me feel sick, because indifference didn't need staging.

"I'm going to the bathroom," I announced.

Nina glanced up, her expression turning careful, and didn't say anything. Owen nodded like he'd been given a cue.

I walked down the hall and shut the bathroom door harder than necessary. The fan kicked on with a thin mechanical whir. I stared at myself in the mirror like my reflection could tell me what counted as reasonable. I washed my hands even though I hadn't used the toilet, then checked my phone without unlocking it. No messages. It shouldn't have mattered. It did anyway.

I stayed longer as if extra minutes alone could turn the feeling into something I could respect. I splashed water on my face, watched it run into the sink, and tried to name what I was carrying without giving it a childish label. Jealousy felt too simple. Suspicion sounded like I'd already lost. Possessiveness felt like admitting something ugly and permanent.

When I came back out, the room had shifted in ways that were easy to deny and hard to ignore. The music was louder. People had switched seats. Owen sat closer to Mara than before, angled toward her like her attention belonged in his direction. Mara looked relaxed, leg crossed, posture open in a way she didn't always allow when she knew I was watching.

I took the chair opposite them and forced myself into conversation. I smiled when others smiled, nodded at the right beats, tried to climb back into the host role, but my eyes kept pulling toward Owen's attention and Mara's responses. Every time Owen said something and Mara laughed, it landed like confirmation. When she corrected him, it didn't help, because the correction carried familiarity, the kind built over time.

Nina caught my eye once, her look saying she saw the tension and didn't know what to do with it. The awareness of being observed made my pride flare in a way that didn't improve anything.

The second game started, and the rules required pairs. People drifted into twos and threes with the easy logic of group nights, and Mara ended up with Owen under the pretense of needing a partner. Owen accepted without hesitation, like the decision had been made earlier. I could've insisted. I didn't. I told myself objecting would make me look childish, which meant I didn't want anyone to see how exposed I felt.

Mara leaned toward the table to pick up cards, hair slipping forward, and Owen's hand lifted as if to brush it back. He stopped a fraction short, hovering, then dropped his hand, but the near-touch landed the same way a touch would have. I looked away fast enough to avoid being caught staring, then hated myself for reacting at all.

My phone buzzed in my pocket. I pulled it out automatically, and my stomach tightened when I saw Mara's name.

"Don't be weird."

It was simple and precise, and it hit like a correction delivered in front of an audience even though no one else could see it. I stared at the screen, thumb hovering. Every reply sounded like an admission. I typed "I'm not," deleted it. I typed "What do you mean," deleted that too. I locked my phone without answering because silence felt like the only move that didn't hand her proof.

Across from me, Mara's gaze flicked to my hand, then to my face. Her expression didn't change, but the look carried a warning. Owen followed

her line of sight, saw my reaction, and his smile turned faintly pleased, like he'd been handed leverage without asking.

I tried to regain footing the way I always did when I felt exposed. I performed competence. I explained scoring twice, corrected Ben when he mangled a rule, refilled drinks without being asked, laughed harder than necessary at Nina's jokes as if volume could substitute for ease. It worked on the surface, which only made me feel more isolated, because everyone else stayed on the surface and I couldn't.

Mara and Owen played together with irritating efficiency. They didn't need constant consultation, and that made it worse, because it suggested they'd learned how to move without speaking. When they did exchange a look, it was brief and clean, like shorthand they didn't translate. To anyone else it was teamwork. To me it read like a private language I wasn't fluent in anymore.

At one point Owen leaned back and his knee bumped Mara's under the table. It could've been an accident, except he didn't move away right after. His leg stayed there, steady pressure hidden from the room. Mara didn't jerk back either. She kept sorting cards, expression neutral, but her fingers slowed a fraction as if her attention had shifted.

I told myself I was imagining it, then watched Mara's foot slide half an inch and Owen's knee move with it, a small synchronized adjustment that didn't read as random. It was subtle, almost nothing, and the fact that it was almost nothing made it harder to challenge without sounding unstable.

My phone buzzed again, and this time I didn't want to look. I kept my hand still, pretending I hadn't felt it, because I couldn't handle another message in the middle of the table. The vibration stopped. I forced my breathing to stay even, kept my face steady, then checked anyway under the table because self-control wasn't holding.

The message was from Owen.

"Relax. You're making it obvious."

My throat went dry. For a second I tried to tell myself it had been meant for someone else, a wrong thread, a joke sent to the wrong person. Then my eyes lifted and met his across the table, and he didn't look surprised at all. He looked entertained, like he'd finally pulled a wire and watched it spark.

I closed my phone slowly, keeping my face neutral while my pulse climbed. Mara's fingers tapped the edge of her cards, once, twice, like she was counting something I couldn't hear. Her gaze slid to me and held for a

moment too long, calm enough to be cruel, and then she looked away as if I'd been handled.

The game moved on. Laughter rose, dice rolled, someone argued about rules again, and the room kept pretending nothing had changed. Under the table, Owen's knee stayed where it was. Mara didn't shift. I sat there with a smile I couldn't feel, listening to my own blood in my ears, waiting for the next small thing that would be easy to deny and impossible to forget.

Chapter 2

I told Nina I was fine because I didn't have a better answer, and because saying anything else would've made it real in a way I couldn't control. I pocketed my phone with a slow, deliberate motion, like I was choosing calm, then forced myself back into the game, laughing at the wrong moments and missing obvious plays because my attention kept drifting to the space under the table where I couldn't actually see anything and still felt like I could.

The round ended with Mara and Owen winning again, and people reacted the way people did when they were half-drunk and mildly competitive, groaning and accusing and joking about cheating. Owen lifted his hands in mock innocence and said, "Talent," like it couldn't be helped. Mara rolled her eyes like she'd heard the line before and knew exactly how much to indulge. That familiarity landed harder than it should've. It wasn't flirtation that got under my skin. It was the ease inside it.

I stood under the pretense of clearing the table, and the moment I did, Mara's eyes followed me. Not worried. Not apologetic. Simply attentive, like she expected I'd be useful rather than disruptive. Owen watched too, and I hated that he watched, hated the way his attention sat on me like a hand at the base of my neck.

In the kitchen I busied myself with cups and napkins, listening to the muffled noise from the living room. I tried to let ordinary sounds reset my head, but Owen's message kept replaying, "Relax. You're making it obvious," and the irritation spread until it felt less like a feeling and more like pressure behind my ribs. It wasn't only that he'd said it. It was that he'd felt entitled, like he could manage me in my own apartment, like he could correct my behavior and expect obedience.

My phone buzzed on the counter where I'd set it down. I considered not looking and looked anyway.

Mara: "Stop spiraling. Come back."

I stared at the screen longer than necessary. The words weren't warm. They weren't gentle. They were efficient, like a boss calling an employee back to the floor. I typed "Owen texted me," then deleted it because I didn't

want to sound like I was tattling. I typed “Are you enjoying this?” then deleted that too because it sounded like begging. I sent nothing, which felt weak and safer at the same time, then shoved the phone into my pocket like it could burn through fabric.

When I walked back into the living room, the group had split into smaller clusters, and the energy had slid from game-night noise into that looser late-night intimacy where people stood closer and let jokes run too long. Ben was on the balcony with one of my coworkers, talking with his hands. Nina sat on the couch, watching everything with quiet focus that made me uneasy because she didn’t need a confession to form an opinion.

Mara wasn’t on the couch. She stood near the bookshelf with Owen, both holding drinks, angled toward each other like the rest of the room was background.

They weren’t touching, but they were too close for a conversation that didn’t matter. Owen said something and Mara laughed, head tipping back slightly, throat exposed in a way that was careless and deliberate at the same time. Owen’s eyes followed the movement. Then Mara’s gaze slid past him and landed on me as I entered, and her smile didn’t fade. That made it worse than guilt would’ve.

I crossed the room and inserted myself by stepping beside Mara, close enough that my arm brushed hers. It was a subtle claim, and I disliked myself for making it. Mara didn’t move away, and she didn’t lean into me either. She accepted my proximity the same way she’d accepted Owen’s, like both were facts that didn’t require commentary.

Owen lifted his glass. “There he is.”

I kept my voice light. “Yeah. Just doing host stuff.”

“Host stuff,” Owen repeated, amused, as if the phrase itself gave me away. Then he looked at Mara and said, “He’s trying.”

Mara kept her eyes on mine when she answered, “He always tries,” and the tone made it impossible to tell whether it was praise or critique.

Something twisted in my chest, part anger, part embarrassment, part something darker I didn’t want to name. I wanted to pull her closer, to remind her, but there were too many people around and too many ways it could fail. Mara’s friends were in the room; Nina was watching; Owen would enjoy it either way. I did nothing, and the restraint only made me feel more exposed.

Owen shifted so his shoulder angled toward Mara, forcing me to crowd in or back off. The move was small and deniable. I held my position and looked at him steadily.

“What’d you text me for?” I asked, keeping my tone conversational even as my pulse picked up.

Owen’s eyebrows rose a fraction. “Text you?”

I didn’t pull my phone out. I didn’t want to turn it into an exhibit. “Telling me to relax.”

His expression stayed pleasant. “I was joking.”

Mara’s eyes flicked to him, then back to me. “Eli,” she said quietly, and my name sounded like a warning dressed as concern.

I wanted to say Don’t do that. Don’t side with him in front of people. Don’t look at me like I’m the unstable one while he pushes. Instead I heard myself say, “Yeah, okay,” because the room was watching even if they weren’t listening, and because Mara made it clear without saying it that the worst thing I could do was make a scene.

Owen took a sip of wine and smiled like he’d won again. Mara didn’t smile, and she didn’t correct him either, and the absence of correction rang louder than anything he could’ve said.

I stayed beside her anyway, close enough to feel heat through her sleeve, and treated the conversation like neutral territory. Owen started talking about a new restaurant, describing cocktails with the kind of detail that made it sound like he was selling an experience rather than a drink. Mara asked questions, not too many, but enough to keep him going, and I watched how naturally she slid into that rhythm with him, how she didn’t look at him like he was trying too hard, but like she liked the effort.

Nina wandered over with a bowl of pretzels and a careful expression she tried to pass off as casual. “Are we doing another round or are we just talking now?” she asked, tone light in the way people got when they were trying to steer away from the edge of something.

“We can do another,” I said quickly, grateful for a task.

Mara’s hand landed on my forearm, brief pressure, and she looked at me with something close to kindness. “Babe, you don’t have to.”

The word babe should’ve anchored me. Instead it landed like she was smoothing me down for the benefit of everyone else, like she was calming an animal that might bolt. I nodded and said, “It’s fine,” because the alternative would’ve sounded like a confession.

Owen's phone buzzed on the shelf behind him, and he glanced down without picking it up. His eyes flicked to Mara's face, then to me, and my stomach dropped because the look carried a question or a signal or both. Mara didn't look at his phone. She lifted her glass and took a slow sip, and I couldn't tell whether she was hiding a smile or steadying herself.

I excused myself to the kitchen and started gathering empty cups with more force than necessary. Laughter rose and fell behind me. I kept imagining Owen leaning in, imagining Mara angling toward him, imagining the private space they could create in the middle of my apartment. Part of me knew I was building scenes in my head worse than anything I could prove, but the lack of proof didn't calm me. It irritated me. It made me feel like I was losing without being allowed to name the game.

My phone buzzed in my pocket. I pulled it out before I could talk myself out of it.

Another message from Owen: "Take a breath. She's fine."

I stared at the words until they blurred. "She's fine" sounded intimate in a way that had nothing to do with sex and everything to do with access. It implied he knew her state better than I did, or felt entitled to reassure me about it. I typed "Stop texting me," then deleted it because it would sound defensive. I typed "Why are you doing this," then deleted that too because it gave him too much credit, and he already had enough.

I wrote, "Don't," and sent it before I could reconsider.

His reply came a few seconds later: "Then tell her."

The message hit like a shove. My hand tightened around the phone, and for a moment I wanted to walk into the living room and demand an explanation from Mara in front of everyone, not because I thought it would go well, but because I wanted to stop feeling managed from both sides. I didn't do it. I stood in the kitchen breathing through my nose, trying to hold my face still, trying to make my body obey a script it wasn't written for.

When I finally went back, the room had shifted again. The balcony door stood open, letting in cool air and faint city noise. Ben had moved inside and was now explaining something to one of Mara's yoga friends with exaggerated seriousness. Nina sat on the couch again, her gaze fixed on Mara with quiet concentration.

Owen wasn't by the bookshelf anymore.

Mara was.

Owen stood in the hallway just beyond the living room light, half in shadow, like he'd stepped out to take a call or use the bathroom. He looked up as I entered and met my eyes in a way that felt deliberate, like he wanted me to register exactly where he was. Then his gaze slid past me toward Mara, and I saw Mara notice too, the smallest shift of her eyes, the tiniest pause in her breathing.

She lifted her phone from the coffee table and glanced at it. I didn't need to see the screen to know what it said. I watched her thumb hover, and a cold clarity settled in: she was deciding whether to go to him, and the fact that it was a decision at all tightened my throat.

Mara stood there with her phone in her hand like it weighed nothing and everything, and for a moment I didn't move because I couldn't pick the lesser humiliation. Step toward her like a guard dog, or hold back like a man who'd already accepted defeat. The room kept talking and laughing and arguing about rules that didn't matter, and the ordinary noise made the private shift between Mara and Owen feel louder inside my head.

Mara met my eyes without panic or guilt, only that composed, assessing look she used when she wanted control more than comfort. She set her drink down, slid the phone into her back pocket, and said, to no one in particular, "I'm going to check on something," which sounded like nothing and still landed like a verdict.

I followed her into the hallway because the idea of her moving toward Owen while I stayed on the couch pretending to laugh tightened something in my chest until it hurt. I kept my pace normal, not rushing, not stalking, trying to make it look like coincidence, like I had my own reason to be there.

Mara walked ahead with that calm stride that made her look like she knew exactly where she was going. She didn't look back to see if I was coming, which landed worse than a glance would've.

The hallway was dimmer, the living-room noise muffled as soon as we stepped out of it, and the shift felt like a door closing.

Owen was near the bathroom, leaning against the wall, phone in hand like he'd been waiting. He looked at Mara first, then at me, and his expression barely changed, but the flicker of satisfaction was there if you wanted to see it. Mara stopped a few feet away, close enough for privacy, far enough for deniability, and said, "What," not as a question so much as a demand.

Owen's eyes stayed on her, not on me, and the exclusion landed like a physical thing.

"You disappeared," he said, low enough that the living room wouldn't catch it. "I thought you were going to the kitchen."

"I went to the kitchen," Mara said. "Then I came back."

"And then you didn't come over here," Owen said, mouth curving.

Mara tilted her head slightly, almost lazy, with an edge underneath. "Were you expecting me to?"

"I was hoping," Owen said, and the quiet confidence in it made my pulse jump.

I stepped in before I could stop myself. "What's going on?"

Mara's eyes flicked to me and hardened a degree, like I'd interrupted something she was already controlling. "Nothing is going on," she said, and the precision of it sounded more like instruction than reassurance.

Owen lifted his phone slightly, hinting at evidence without offering it. "It's just a conversation," he said, and the word just tightened my jaw.

I kept my voice even. "Why are you texting me?"

Owen's eyebrows rose in practiced surprise. "Because you're tense."

"I told you not to," I said.

His gaze slid to Mara and he said to her, not to me, "He's wound up."

Mara didn't flinch. She didn't correct him. She looked at me with that calm stare that made me feel like the unstable variable in the room. "Eli," she said again, and my name hit like a leash.

I took a breath through my nose, then asked the question I'd been dodging all night because it sounded weak the moment it left my mouth. "Did you want him here?"

Mara's lips parted slightly and real annoyance crossed her face, not aimed at Owen, aimed at me, like I'd forced her into a choice she preferred to keep blurred. She looked between us, measuring, then said, "I invited him because you said you wanted to have people over."

"That's not what I meant," I said, and my frustration sharpened the words more than I intended.

Owen's laugh came out quiet, almost sympathetic. "Come on, man."

I turned toward him. "Don't."

Mara's hand came up and rested on my chest, not pushing, not pulling, just contact, steady and firm, a familiar gesture that stopped me when she wanted me stopped. "This is not the time," she said, low and controlled.

Owen watched her hand on me with a look that turned my stomach. Not jealousy. Interest. Like he was studying the mechanism, how she could settle me with her palm against my shirt. He shifted slightly, and the narrowness of the hallway pressed in, how close we all were, how easy it would be for shoulders to brush and breath to overlap and a moment to become something nobody could take back even if they called it accidental.

Mara removed her hand and turned toward the bathroom like she was going to end the situation by doing something mundane. "I'm going to use the bathroom," she said.

"I'll wait," Owen said too quickly, too automatically, like waiting for her was a role he'd already claimed.

Mara held his gaze for a beat. The air went still, because the question hanging there didn't need words. Then she opened the door and stepped inside without looking at either of us. The door clicked shut, and the small sound felt final.

Owen turned to me, and in the dim hallway his expression sharpened into something less polished. "You're doing this wrong," he said quietly.

"What the hell does that mean?" My voice came out raw, and I disliked that too.

His smile returned, faint and controlled. "It means she doesn't respond to pressure," he said. "She responds to confidence."

Heat rose in my face. "You don't know her."

Owen's gaze flicked to the bathroom door and back. "Do you want to bet?" he said, and there was no humor in it.

Behind the door the faucet turned on, water running, and I stood there listening like it was a countdown.

The water ran longer, which told me Mara was buying time, and the fact that she needed time at all tightened my stomach. Owen stayed where he was, leaning against the wall like he belonged there, like he had every right to occupy that narrow strip outside my bathroom. I wanted to tell him to move, to go back into the living room, to stop turning my apartment into a stage, but I could already hear how it would sound if I said it, small and threatened, the exact tone he'd been provoking.

I forced my voice steady. "Go back out there."

Owen didn't take his eyes off me. "You want me to?"

"Yes," I said, and the repetition made it feel worse, not stronger.

He considered me like he was deciding whether obeying would give him more leverage later. "If I go back in," he said, "are you going to keep looking at her like she owes you something?"

My jaw tightened. "She does owe me something."

Owen's mouth curved without warmth. "That's the problem."

The bathroom door opened before I could respond. Mara stepped out, hands damp, hair slightly looser, face composed again. She looked at Owen first, then at me, and the order of it struck me with irrational force. She didn't ask what we'd said while she was gone, like she didn't need the words to know the shape of it.

"What are you two doing?" she asked quietly, and there was no softness in the question.

"Nothing," I said automatically.

"Talking," Owen said at the same time, and Mara's eyes narrowed because she hated bad lies.

She glanced toward the living room where voices rose and fell, a reminder that we were supposed to be normal, then looked back at Owen. "Go back in," she said.

He didn't move right away. He watched her like he wanted to see whether she'd repeat it or let it fade. Mara held his gaze without blinking. Owen finally pushed off the wall and stepped past her, close enough that his shoulder nearly brushed her arm. He could've avoided it if he wanted to. Mara didn't react either way.

Owen walked back into the living room with the same relaxed posture, but the air changed after he left, like he'd taken something with him.

Mara turned to me. "What is happening with you?"

"I'm fine," I said, because I still couldn't stop myself, even though it had become a lie I repeated out of habit.

Her expression tightened. "No, you're not."

I met her eyes. "He's texting me," I said. "All night."

Mara's gaze flicked toward my pocket and back. "And?"

"And it's weird," I said. "It's patronizing. It's like he's trying to manage me."

"Then ignore him," she said, and the simplicity of it made anger flare.

"That's easy for you to say," I said, and the edge in my voice made her eyes flash.

“What does that mean?” Her tone stayed calm, the kind of calm that warned me she could get colder if I pushed.

I swallowed. “It means he’s acting like you’re his,” I said. “Like he knows you better than I do.”

Mara stared at me for a beat, then let out a short laugh without humor. “That’s what this is,” she said. “Ownership.”

“It’s respect,” I said.

She stepped closer, close enough that I could smell lime on her breath. “If you respected me,” she said, “you wouldn’t talk about me like I’m something you can lose.”

“That’s not what I meant,” I said, and it sounded like pleading even when I tried to keep it firm.

“But it is what you feel,” she said, not cruel, simply accurate. “You’re scared I’m going to choose something else.”

I wanted to deny it and couldn’t. The denial stuck in my throat because it wasn’t honest. “I don’t like him doing this,” I said.

Mara’s eyes stayed on mine. “Then stop letting him be the one who tells you what you are,” she said, and there was a chill under it, like she wasn’t offering comfort so much as setting terms.

Owen’s voice carried from the living room, loud enough to reach the hallway. “Mara,” he called, casual, like he was calling her over to settle a bet. “Come settle this.”

Mara didn’t look toward the room right away. She kept her eyes on me, and that small delay held the weight of choice again. Then she turned her head slightly and called back, “In a minute.”

Owen’s reply came quick, amused. “We’ll be waiting.”

Mara looked back at me, composure back in place, eyes bright with something that could’ve been irritation or adrenaline. “Are you coming back in there with me,” she asked, “or are you going to hide in the kitchen?”

The question was challenge and invitation at once. I knew backing away would read like weakness to Owen and refusal to Mara. Going back in and trying to clamp down on her would lose in a different direction.

“I’m coming,” I said.

Mara nodded once, like it was the correct answer, and stepped past me toward the living room. As she passed, she caught my hand briefly, not long

enough to make a display, just long enough to make the point: she could include me if she wanted, and she could let go just as easily.

I followed her back into the room with my pulse loud in my ears and the sense that every move would be read by anyone who mattered.

When we stepped into the living room, conversations didn't stop, but the room registered us in that subtle way groups did, a few heads turning and then turning away like everyone was pretending they hadn't noticed the couple disappearing into the hall. Nina held my gaze a beat longer than polite, then looked down at her drink as if she'd decided not to be the person who got involved.

Owen sat on the edge of the coffee table like it was his chair, ankle crossed, hands loose, posture relaxed in the way that always felt intentional. He was in the middle of a story and didn't pause when we came in. He widened his smile and kept going, which made it feel like he was welcoming us back into something he was already running.

Mara moved to the couch and sat open and unguarded, taking up space like she belonged to herself. I sat beside her, close enough that our knees almost touched, and forced my shoulders to drop even though my body wanted to stay braced.

Owen finished the story to a few laughs, then looked at Mara. "So," he said, "you tell them."

Mara lifted her eyebrows. "Why am I telling them?"

"Because you were there," Owen said. "And you're the only one who remembers it correctly."

Mara's mouth curved. "That's not true. I remember it correctly because you refuse to."

Owen laughed and spread his hands. "See? This is why I need her."

My jaw tightened, but I kept my face neutral. I wanted, suddenly and with embarrassing intensity, to be the version of myself who could sit there and let Owen play to the room without flinching, the version who didn't need Mara to keep proving where she stood. Instead I watched her speak, watched him watch her, watched the way the room leaned into the energy without naming it.

When Mara finished, someone clapped lightly. Owen said, "Exactly," like he'd won a point, then looked at me. "You remember that night, right?"

I took a breath. "Yeah. I remember it."

Owen tilted his head. "You were quieter back then."

Mara's eyes flicked to me, a quick check. I kept my tone even. "I'm still quiet."

"Not tonight," Owen said, and there was a faint challenge in it.

I could feel the group hovering near interest, the way people sensed conflict and pretended they didn't while leaning toward it. Mara didn't intervene. She let the moment sit, like she wanted to see what I'd do with it.

I kept my face calm. "I'm hosting," I said. "That requires talking."

Owen's smile widened like approval, and it irritated me that it mattered. "Fair," he said. "Then host. Pick the next thing."

Mara's hand slid onto my thigh briefly, a light squeeze that could've been encouragement or warning, then withdrew like nothing had happened. My skin stayed warm where her fingers had been, and I was suddenly aware of how precisely she used touch in public, how she used it like punctuation.

"We can do another round," I said, and stood to gather the cards, aware of Owen's eyes on me, Mara's eyes on me, Nina's eyes on me, and the ugly, immediate need to look like I belonged in my own life.

As I bent to collect the deck, my phone buzzed again in my pocket. I didn't check it. I didn't want to give him the satisfaction of seeing me reach for it. I kept my hand still and let the vibration die against my thigh.

Across the room, Owen lifted his glass toward Mara, like a toast meant for her alone. Mara didn't return it. She didn't refuse it either. She just watched him over the rim of her drink, calm and unreadable, like she was deciding how much of the night belonged to her and how much belonged to the story he was trying to write.

I set the cards on the table and looked up into a room that had the shape of a party and the tension of something else. Mara's knee brushed mine as she shifted, deliberate or careless, I couldn't tell. Owen smiled like he could.

And I realized, with a low, sick certainty, that whatever was happening wasn't going to end cleanly when the guests left. It was already in the apartment. It was already in her smile. It was already in my silence.

Chapter 3

I gathered the cards and worked too hard to make my hands look steady, which was an absurd thing to care about until you were in a room where confidence felt finite and someone kept testing how much was left. People leaned back as I shuffled, the deck snapping and sliding louder than it should've, and I told myself I was reacting to ordinary noise, even though nothing in the room felt ordinary anymore. Owen's attention stayed on Mara too long, Mara let it stay there, and my focus kept jumping between them like it couldn't decide where the danger lived.

We started a new game with prompts and answers, the kind that turned everyone into comedians for the length of a drink, which helped because laughter covered tension the way music covered a conversation you weren't supposed to hear. Owen ran the room without announcing it, dropping lines that landed clean, then leaning back as if the rhythm had formed on its own. Mara played along, reading prompts in her clear voice, checking my face now and then to see whether I was still here or slipping somewhere dark. I stayed present on purpose, not because it came naturally, but because I knew how quickly she lost patience for panic disguised as sensitivity.

Ben knocked his drink onto the rug and the room erupted into a collective groan, drunk enough to make a minor spill into a spectacle. I stood to grab paper towels because being useful was my oldest reflex and because movement kept me from sitting still long enough to spiral. Mara stood too, saying she'd handle it, and Owen stood as well, moving toward her with a speed that looked like instinct.

"I've got it," I said quickly, reaching the spill first.

Owen stopped a half step behind me. "I can help," he offered.

Mara's gaze moved over both of us and she said, "Eli, you do it," in a tone that sounded like an assignment, not comfort. Owen held her eyes an extra beat, then nodded and stepped back, smiling at Ben like none of it mattered. I got on my knees and blotted the rug while apologies and jokes bounced around the room, and Mara stayed standing above me, watching. The arrangement felt wrong in a way I couldn't explain without sounding

unhinged, like I'd been placed somewhere on purpose so someone else could remain upright.

When I finished and washed my hands in the kitchen, I caught my reflection in the dark window above the sink and saw the tension in my shoulders, the tightness around my eyes. Behind me, the apartment lights reflected as soft rectangles, and for a second I pictured how it looked from outside: warm room, normal party, a crowd inside. Me alone in the kitchen, acting like the world had narrowed to one man's grin and one woman's composure.

My phone buzzed. I didn't want to check it, but my body knew the sequence before my brain decided anything, so I looked.

A message from Mara: "Stay with me."

Three words, simple, not tender, not soothing, just direct enough to land. My pulse slowed a fraction, not because it fixed anything, but because it clarified what I'd been losing. Mara wasn't absent. Mara was watching. Mara was choosing, moment by moment, where to place me.

I went back into the living room and sat beside her again, close enough that our shoulders brushed when I settled. She didn't look at me right away, but her hand moved to rest on my knee under the cover of conversation, fingers warm, pressure light and steady. No display, no performance, just contact that said I wasn't alone in this. Across from us, Owen watched the movement with a faint smile that didn't reach his eyes, and I understood he'd noticed the same thing I had: Mara was still in control, and she was deciding how much of that control to share.

Mara kept her hand on my knee longer than she usually would in front of people, and I refused to cling to it like it was rescue because I could feel how easily she could turn the gesture into another measure. The pressure stayed light, almost absent, but it changed the way I sat and the way I breathed and the way I heard the room, and I hated how quickly my body responded to something so small. Owen noticed, of course. He didn't look away as if he'd been caught; he held the look with that quiet amusement, as if he understood the mechanics even if he didn't understand the cost.

The game rolled on with people tossing down answers and laughing, alcohol smoothing conversation into something easier, but I couldn't settle fully. Every time Mara laughed at Owen, I listened for a difference, for a private warmth I couldn't touch. Every time Owen leaned in to say something to her, I measured the distance and pretended I was measuring

something else. Knowing it was pathetic didn't stop it; it only added shame to the heat.

Nina slid onto the arm of the couch opposite us, close enough to speak without raising her voice. "You two okay?" she asked, looking at Mara as much as she looked at me, which made it harder to treat as a casual check-in.

Mara smiled politely. "We're fine."

Nina's eyes flicked to Mara's hand on my knee and back to my face. "Right," she said, and I couldn't tell whether she believed it or had decided to let it pass.

Owen took a sip of wine. "They're fine. It's just a lot of personality in one room." He made it sound like a compliment and a critique at once, and the way he included himself in it made my teeth itch. I forced a laugh and said, "Yeah, you're exhausting," and people chuckled because it sounded like friend banter.

Mara's fingers tightened slightly on my knee, a subtle correction, and I adjusted my posture, leaning back as if I was comfortable. The performance of comfort took effort, but it mattered because Mara was watching the performance, and Owen was watching too, and I refused to give either of them the satisfaction of seeing me crack.

A little later, one of Mara's yoga friends announced she needed air, and Ben followed her onto the balcony with the eagerness of someone who treated conversation like a sport. The room thinned as people rotated in and out, and the shifting made it easier for Owen to end up closer again, like the furniture had been arranged for him. He sat on the far end of the couch angled toward Mara, and the distance felt chosen even if he treated it like accident.

"I missed you guys," Owen said, eyes on Mara. "College was messy, but it was simple."

Mara lifted her eyebrows. "College was not simple."

"It was simple," Owen insisted. "You didn't overthink everything."

Mara's mouth curved. "That's funny. I overthought everything. I just didn't tell you I was doing it."

Owen laughed, warm and a little too pleased. "See? That's what I'm talking about."

Mara's hand stayed on my knee, steady. I could feel my body tightening and I knew she could too. She didn't move her hand away. She kept it there,

like she wanted me to tolerate the proximity and the conversation and Owen's attention without demanding she shut it down. The realization settled into place and it didn't feel flattering. It felt like pressure. This wasn't only about whether Owen was flirting. It was about whether I could sit still while another man tried.

The idea that it was a test made me want to reject it, but Mara behaved differently when she tested something. She got smoother, more deliberate, less reactive, like she was watching the situation from a step above it. She did it when we argued. She did it when she negotiated. Tonight she was doing it again with Owen in my apartment, Nina on the edge of the room, choices measured, face composed, observing how I moved under heat.

I tried to move through it with dignity. I stayed on the couch. I didn't check my phone. I laughed when Ben shouted something from the balcony that was meant to be funny. I drank slowly, because too much alcohol would turn jealousy into clumsy honesty. I let Owen talk without interrupting him, which felt like swallowing something sharp and keeping my smile anyway.

Owen leaned forward to reach for a chip and his shoulder brushed Mara's upper arm. The touch was light, probably accidental, and Mara didn't shift away. Her body stayed relaxed, and the lack of reaction made it normal to everyone else. To me it felt like another line being tested. I glanced at Mara's face to see whether she'd noticed. She had. Her expression stayed neutral, which meant she'd decided it didn't deserve acknowledgment.

Owen sat back with the chip between his fingers and said, "So, Mara, what are you doing now? Like, work-wise."

The question wasn't innocent. He already knew what she did. He asked anyway because he wanted her talking, because he liked hearing her voice in front of other people, because he liked making space for her as if he'd earned the right. Part of me could admire it in the abstract. Most of me resented it.

Mara answered with her usual precision, the project, the people, the timeline, interesting without oversharing. Owen listened like he was taking notes, nodding at the right points, then said, "You're always like that," vague enough to be safe and personal enough to land.

"Like what?" Mara asked.

"Capable," Owen said. "Like you could walk into a room and change the temperature without trying."

Mara's mouth curved slightly. "That's dramatic."

"It's accurate," Owen said, gaze fixed on her. He didn't look at me to soften it. He let it hang, and the room absorbed it the way rooms absorbed compliments that felt too intimate.

Nina shifted and made a small sound that could've been a laugh or a warning. "Okay, poet," she said, trying to drain it of weight.

Owen smiled, charming and unbothered. "I'm observant."

Mara glanced at me then, quick. My stomach tightened because I couldn't tell whether she was checking for damage or checking for strength. I met her eyes and gave her a small smile, the kind that said I'm still here. Her gaze held mine a beat longer, then she looked away and took a sip like that ended the moment.

My phone buzzed against my thigh, muffled in my pocket. I didn't reach for it. Mara's hand stayed on my knee and her fingers pressed once, light but clear, as if she'd felt the vibration too and was acknowledging my restraint.

Owen's gaze flicked down for a split second toward our hands. He saw her hand on me. He saw my stillness. His expression didn't change, but something in his eyes tightened, and the satisfaction I'd seen earlier thinned into calculation.

I didn't know what game Owen thought he was playing, but I could feel the pattern: push, wait, push again, watching for me to overreact. Overreacting wouldn't only make me look bad to him. It would make me look bad to Mara, and Mara was the one who mattered.

Still, when Owen leaned in again and said to Mara, low enough to be almost private, "You know you could do anything you want," something in me cinched tight. Not enough to break, enough to sharpen into a boundary. This wasn't only insecurity. It was my limits being treated like they were optional.

I leaned slightly toward Mara, close enough that only she could hear. "Do you want him to stop?"

She didn't answer right away. She kept her eyes on the table and her hand stayed on my knee, steady. Then, without turning her head, she said softly, "I want you to stay with me."

It wasn't yes or no. It was instruction, and it landed deeper than either answer would've.

I stayed with her because the alternative was forcing clarity in front of people who didn't deserve it and in front of Owen, who would enjoy it. Her answer wasn't comfort; it was alignment, a way of saying I was still her primary reference point even if she refused to perform ownership out loud. The problem was that part of me wanted ownership anyway, not because I thought Mara belonged to me, but because being challenged in public made me crave something blunt and undeniable. Mara didn't do blunt. Mara did chosen. Mara did deliberate. Mara did control, and she expected me to survive it.

The room shifted as people stood and wandered, a few heading out, a few moving toward the kitchen for more drinks. Nina got up to refill her cup and called out, "Anyone want anything?" and half the room shouted requests like she was behind a bar. Mara lifted her glass slightly and I stood with her, because staying with her meant more than sitting beside her. It meant moving with her, matching her pace, not letting Owen dictate the geometry.

We went into the kitchen together. The counter was cluttered with bottles and limes and a half-open bag of chips, the sink crowded with cups. Mara leaned against the counter and looked at me with that steady gaze that always made me feel seen and evaluated at the same time.

"You're doing better," she said.

The phrasing, like feedback, brought heat to my face. "Better," I repeated. "So this is a performance review now?"

Her mouth curved slightly. "If you want to call it that."

I exhaled sharply. "Why are you letting him talk to you like that?"

"Like what?" Mara asked, eyes steady.

"You know," I said, frustration pushing my voice up. "Like he's got a claim. Like he's courting you in my living room."

Mara let the word hang without flinching. "He's talking," she said. "You're assigning meaning."

"That's insulting," I said, and I heard the rawness in my own tone, control sliding.

"No," Mara said. "It's accurate. I can deal with Owen. What I can't deal with is you turning every sentence into a threat."

I swallowed, because the truth of it had weight. "He's texting me," I said again, quieter this time, like repetition might make it land.

Mara's gaze sharpened. "Show me."

I hesitated, and the hesitation exposed something I didn't like: part of me didn't want her to see the texts because they'd become my private proof, my fuel. If she dismissed them, I'd lose the justification I'd been using to carry my anger. I took the phone out anyway, opened the thread, and angled the screen toward her.

Mara read silently, eyes moving, face giving nothing away. When she reached "Then tell her," her mouth tightened, not guilt, irritation.

"He's being an ass," I said, and I tried to keep the plea out of my voice.

Mara handed the phone back. "Yes," she said. "He is."

Relief flashed through me so fast it felt humiliating, like my body had been waiting for permission. "So..."

"So you don't take bait," Mara cut in.

I stared at her. "That's it?"

"What do you want me to do, Eli?" Mara asked, gaze firm. "Kick him out in front of everyone? Make it ugly? Prove something to you?"

I opened my mouth and didn't know what to put in it, because some part of me did want proof, not because I doubted her, but because the situation had scraped something primitive in me and I didn't know what to do with it besides demand a gesture. Mara seemed to read the flicker.

She stepped closer and her hand slid up my chest, fingers resting lightly at the base of my throat, just enough pressure to still me. Her voice dropped, intimate but controlled. "Listen," she said. "I chose you. I'm here. I'm in your apartment. I'm touching you." Her thumb moved, a small stroke that sent a jolt through me I hated and wanted at the same time. "But if you make me choose in a way that feels like punishment, I'll resent you."

The directness landed in my gut. I nodded once. "Okay."

Mara held my gaze a beat longer, deciding whether I meant it, then withdrew her hand and reached for the tequila like we were back to hosting. "Help me," she said, softer now, not tender, collaborative.

I filled the shaker with ice and the mundane task steadied me by giving my hands somewhere to go. Mara squeezed limes and poured, and our movements slipped into the rhythm we had when we cooked together, a domestic coordination that reminded me we had a life outside Owen.

Then Owen appeared in the kitchen doorway like he'd been drawn by the shift in attention. He leaned casually against the frame, eyes moving between us and the bottles. "I'm missing the fun?" he asked.

Mara didn't look startled or guilty. She looked mildly annoyed, like he'd interrupted something. "We're making drinks," she said.

Owen's gaze flicked to me, then back to her. "Looks like more than that."

"Don't," Mara said, and the firmness in it was new, unmistakable.

Owen's smile didn't vanish, but it changed. "Okay," he said lightly. "Just checking."

A grim satisfaction moved through me at hearing her set the boundary, followed immediately by the dangerous part of that satisfaction, the part that wanted more, the part that wanted to see how far she'd go if I asked. I shoved it down and shook the drinks harder than necessary, letting the ice rattle.

Mara took the shaker, poured, and handed Owen a glass without looking at him. "Go," she said.

Owen lingered half a beat, then stepped away with the same easy posture. As he left he glanced back at Mara, and the look carried something unreadable, not triumph, not apology, something closer to a promise.

Mara exhaled slowly and looked at me. "You see?" she said quietly. "I can handle him."

I nodded, and for the first time all night I almost believed it.

We carried the drinks back into the living room and handed them out like we were still only hosts, like nothing had happened in the hallway or the kitchen. The room accepted the new round with gratitude and noise, and for a few minutes the party's momentum blurred the edges again. Someone turned the music up. Ben tried to start a debate about whether a movie was overrated. Nina rolled her eyes and argued back. Normal kept insisting on itself.

I stayed close to Mara without gripping her. I sat when she sat and stood when she stood, trying to make it look like habit rather than fear. Mara seemed to notice the effort and rewarded it with small things: a glance that lingered, her hand grazing my shoulder when she passed behind me, the brief press of her thigh against mine when she shifted. Each touch was subtle enough to read as ordinary affection to anyone else, but I felt the pattern. She was signaling, anchoring, and also reminding Owen where her center was, while keeping the choice visible enough to make me sweat.

Owen didn't retreat. He stayed engaged with the group, telling stories, teasing people, becoming gravity again, but his attention tracked Mara more carefully now, recalibrated after the kitchen. He didn't flirt overtly after

that. He adjusted into something smoother, attention that looked like friendship. It would've been easier if it had been crude. This was harder because it had deniability, and Mara didn't look bothered, which meant my only fight was with my own interpretation.

At one point Mara's yoga friend asked her to show a stretch. Mara laughed and stood, demonstrating with casual grace, arms lifting, shoulders rolling. People watched because Mara drew eyes. Owen watched too, thoughtful, not lewd, and my skin tightened anyway. I forced myself to watch as well, not as a guard, as a partner capable of appreciating her without treating other eyes as theft.

When she sat back down beside me, Owen leaned forward and said, "Still show-off," and Mara smirked and replied, "Still jealous," the exchange sounding like old banter. Irritation rose, then softened because Mara's leg brushed mine and stayed there a beat, a quiet correction that felt like permission and restraint at the same time.

My phone stayed in my pocket. No buzzing, no new provocation. I wondered if Mara had told Owen to stop, or if Owen had decided he'd gotten enough. The uncertainty bothered me less than it had earlier, and that frightened me too.

As the night thinned, people began leaving in clusters. Jackets gathered. Goodbyes exchanged. Promises made without any intent to schedule. Ben left first, loud and apologetic. Mara's yoga friends followed, hugging her and waving at me. A couple of my coworkers stumbled out laughing. Nina lingered, helping with cups, giving me one last look that said she'd be available later if I wanted to talk, which made me grateful and irritated at the same time.

Eventually only Nina, Owen, Mara, and I remained. The apartment felt quieter after a crowd left, like the walls had been pressed and released. The music was low. The kitchen light was too bright for the hour. Empty cups and plates sat on every surface like evidence.

Nina stretched and yawned. "I should go," she said, glancing at Mara. "Text me tomorrow."

Mara nodded. "Drive safe."

Nina looked at me then, expression softer. "Night, Eli."

"Night," I said, and I meant more than the word contained.

Nina put on her coat and left, and the click of the door changed the atmosphere immediately. No crowd. No laughter to blur intent. No

witnesses to dilute meaning.

Owen stood near the window looking out at the city lights like he was thinking. Mara leaned against the counter, arms crossed loosely, watching him with the neutrality she used when she wanted to appear unbothered. My stomach dropped with a cold certainty: this was the moment Owen had been waiting for, the room emptied, the ambiguity allowed to sharpen.

Owen turned from the window and smiled, but the smile had nowhere to soften now. "So," he said, "are we doing the after part of the party?"

Mara lifted her eyebrows. "The after part?"

"You know," Owen said, still casual. "When it's just the real people left."

My pulse picked up again. I didn't move. I stayed beside Mara, close enough to feel heat through the air.

Owen looked between us, then back to Mara. "Honesty," he said, like it was something he could demand because the room had emptied.

Mara set her empty glass down with a soft clink. "Honesty about what?"

Owen stepped closer, not rushing, just closing distance like it was natural. "About tonight," he said. "About what's been happening."

"Nothing's been happening," Mara said.

Owen laughed softly. "Come on."

Mara tilted her head. "You came into my house and poked at my boyfriend all night."

Owen's gaze slid to me. Heat rose in my face. He didn't deny it. "He was already wound up," Owen said, then added like it was praise, "He cares."

"Don't psychoanalyze him," Mara said.

"I'm not," Owen said. "I'm stating what's in front of us." He took a sip, then said, "And you liked it."

The air changed. The comment could be denied if you insisted it was joking, but the weight underneath it was clear. My shoulders tensed before my mind finished choosing what to do.

Mara looked at him steadily. "You're projecting."

"Maybe," Owen said. "But you didn't stop me."

"I didn't stop you because I don't need to," Mara replied.

Owen took another step, close enough that distance mattered in a way neither of them could pretend it didn't. "You could have shut it down," he said. "You didn't."

Mara glanced at me, quick, not asking permission, checking whether I'd hold. I slowed my breathing and gave a small nod, a signal that I wasn't

going to rupture.

She turned back to Owen. "What are you trying to get from this?"

Owen's expression softened and for the first time all night he looked less entertained and more earnest. "I missed you," he said. "And I missed us. Not in a nostalgic way. In the way you don't talk about because it sounds like a confession."

"I don't know what you mean," Mara said.

Owen exhaled like he'd expected the deflection, then looked at me, tone sharpening into something direct. "Are you really okay with how she is?"

The question was a trap framed as concern, designed to make me insult Mara or expose myself. I felt the urge to answer too honestly, just to break the manipulation, and forced myself to keep it clean.

"I'm okay with Mara," I said. "I'm not okay with you trying to run my apartment."

Owen's eyebrows rose. "Run it?"

Mara's gaze stayed on him. "He said stop," she said, and the finality in her voice loosened something in my chest.

Owen lifted both hands in mock surrender. "Okay. Okay. I'll stop." Then he smiled at Mara and added, "If you tell me to."

The silence after that felt thick. He'd bypassed me again, making my boundary dependent on her enforcement, as if my voice didn't exist unless she made it real.

Mara didn't rush. Then she said, low and precise, "Go home."

Owen's smile faltered a fraction, then returned with a slow nod. "Okay," he said.

He set his glass down, picked up his coat, and moved toward the door with a calmness that looked like grace and felt like calculation. At the doorway he paused and looked back at Mara.

"You know where I am," he said.

Mara didn't answer.

Owen looked at me, expression almost sympathetic. Almost. "Take care of her," he said, and the sentence sounded like advice and threat at once.

The door closed behind him with a soft click that felt louder than a slam.

For a moment neither of us moved. The apartment was suddenly too quiet. I stared at the door like I expected it to open again, then looked at Mara. She leaned against the counter, face composed, eyes bright with

something I couldn't name, and the distance between us felt new, like a room had been rearranged without asking.

"Well," I said, because there weren't better words available.

Mara uncrossed her arms slowly and looked at me. "Now," she said, "we're going to talk."

The sentence didn't land like comfort. It landed like a decision, and I understood with a sinking certainty that the real part of the night hadn't ended when the guests left. It had only narrowed, and whatever came next wouldn't resolve cleanly.

Chapter 4

Mara didn't move right away after the door clicked shut. She stayed leaning against the counter, still enough that it felt deliberate, like the wood was an excuse while she decided what version of herself to bring back into the room. I stood a few feet away with my hands at my sides, hollowed out. The party had drained out of the apartment and taken the air with it.

The quiet didn't soothe. It exposed. No voices to hide behind, no laughter to blur intent. Just the two of us, the mess of cups and plates, and the residue of Owen's presence clinging to the place in a way I couldn't point to and couldn't ignore.

Mara looked at me, composed in a way that used to feel like safety and now felt like appraisal. "You were close to losing it," she said.

"I didn't," I replied, true in the technical sense and dishonest everywhere else.

"You almost did." Her eyes held mine without mercy.

I exhaled slowly and rubbed the back of my neck, buying a second, because if I answered too fast I'd answer from pride. "He was pushing," I said. "On purpose."

"I know," Mara said.

The certainty should have helped. Instead it irritated me, because it meant she'd seen everything I'd seen and let it run anyway. "Then why let him stay?" I asked. "Why let it get that far?"

Her gaze drifted to the counter where Owen's glass had been, as if she were replaying the order of the night, then returned to me. "Because you needed to feel it," she said.

The sentence landed dull and heavy. "I needed to feel it," I repeated, my voice sharpening despite myself. "What does that mean?"

Mara pushed off the counter and moved toward the living room, collecting cups as she went, turning the argument into cleanup the way she always did when she refused to let a moment become theater. "It means," she said, "you've been tight lately. About everything. Work. Money. Me. You've been trying to tune the world like it's a set of dials."

I followed her because staying with her meant not letting her talk to furniture. “I’m not trying to control you,” I said.

Mara set a stack of cups into the sink and turned back. “You were tonight,” she said. “You were trying to control how I reacted. Who I looked at. Whether I laughed. Whether I moved.”

“That’s not fair,” I said too quickly, and the speed of my defense made me feel young.

“It’s accurate,” Mara replied, and the evenness of her voice made it harder to argue. “You weren’t asking me how I felt. You were asking me to manage how you felt.”

The words hit too cleanly. I opened my mouth, then closed it again, because I could feel the truth even as I hated hearing it said out loud.

Mara moved back into the kitchen and rinsed a glass. The domestic motion looked wrong after the night we’d just had, like a costume that didn’t fit the scene. “When Owen showed up,” she continued, “it brought something up in you. You didn’t like it. You tried to squash it. Then you tried to put it in my hands.”

I leaned against the counter across from her, keeping space because I couldn’t tell whether closeness would settle me or make me worse. “So what,” I said, “this was a setup?”

Mara stopped rinsing and looked at me fully. “Not a setup,” she said. “A mirror.”

Mirror landed differently. It meant I’d been staring at Owen and seeing a threat when I’d really been staring at Owen and seeing something in myself I didn’t want to admit. It turned my stomach. “And what did I see?” I asked, quieter now.

Mara didn’t look away. “You want to be chosen,” she said. “Not assumed. Not default. You want to feel it.”

Her accuracy felt invasive. “Doesn’t everyone?” I asked.

“Yes,” Mara said. “But you pretend you don’t, because you think wanting it makes you weak.”

The apartment seemed to shrink, not from bodies but from focus. I held her eyes and tried not to retreat into sarcasm. “So you let him flirt with you,” I said slowly, “because you wanted me to want you?”

Mara’s eyes narrowed a fraction, and I recognized the trap I’d built for myself. “No,” she said. “I didn’t do it for him. I didn’t do it to hurt you.” She paused, then delivered the line with the same calm insistence she used

when she knew she was right. “I did it because you’ve been going numb, and I needed you to come back into your body.”

The phrase snagged something under my ribs. I’d been moving through days like lists, fitting intimacy between obligations like it was another task to complete. Mara had noticed. Of course she had.

I forced myself to keep her gaze. “And did it work?” I asked.

Mara’s eyes flicked briefly to my mouth, then back up, a small movement that pulled heat through me like a wire. “You tell me,” she said. “Are you here now?”

I didn’t answer immediately because the answer wasn’t just words. My pulse was steadying. My attention was narrowing. The air felt heavy with lime and alcohol and that thin edge of confrontation that sometimes turned into something else if neither person backed away.

“I’m here,” I said finally.

Mara set the glass down and stepped closer, stopping just inside my space. She didn’t touch me yet. She looked at me like she was deciding what I’d earned. “Then talk,” she said. “Not about Owen. About you.”

My throat tightened. When I spoke my voice came out rougher than I expected. “I hated it,” I admitted. “I hated watching him look at you like he could take his time. I hated that you didn’t shut it down immediately.” I swallowed and forced the last part out because keeping it in would only make it heavier. “I hated that part of me reacted.”

Mara’s expression stayed still, but her eyes sharpened. “Reacted how?”

“Like I wanted to prove something,” I said. “Like I wanted you closer. Like I wanted you to look at me the way you were looking at him.”

Silence stretched, not awkward, charged. Mara’s lips parted slightly. “And you want that now?” she asked.

“Yes,” I said, and the simplicity of it felt like surrender and relief at the same time.

Mara nodded slowly, as if that was the honest answer she’d been pressing for. Then she touched me, her palm sliding onto my chest with firm, steady pressure that stole my breath and quieted my thoughts. “Good,” she said softly. “Now we can stop pretending.”

Her hand wasn’t gentle in the way comfort usually was. It was grounding. It kept me where I was. The pressure made me aware of my breathing and the heat under my skin, the way I’d been coiled all night and was now trying to decide whether I could uncoil without humiliation. Mara

watched my face closely, looking for the flinch, the joke, the retreat into defensiveness. I didn't give her any of it. I stayed still, and the apartment narrowed to the space between us.

"Take your jacket off," she said, and it took me a second to realize I was still wearing it, like some part of me had never fully arrived.

I shrugged it off and let it fall over the back of a chair. Mara's palm remained on my chest as if she could read my pulse through the fabric, confirming the truth of what I'd said about being here.

"Do you want to stop calling it 'Owen' so you don't have to look at yourself?" she asked.

The question was sharp without being cruel. Mara never let me buy an easy villain when the real problem was closer. I exhaled slowly. "It wasn't just him," I said. "It was what he represents."

"And that is?" Her eyebrows lifted slightly.

I swallowed. "Someone who doesn't second-guess," I said. "Someone who walks into a room and assumes people will want him there. I don't do that. I always feel like I have to earn my place."

Mara's gaze softened a fraction, and that softness tightened my throat. It wasn't pity. It was recognition. "And you think I don't want you unless you're earning," she said.

"I don't know what I think," I admitted. "I know that when he looked at you, part of me felt like you could choose him because he's easy. Because he's confident. Because he doesn't need anything."

"Owen needs plenty," Mara said. "He just packages it better."

A breath escaped me that was almost a laugh. "Maybe."

Mara's hand slid from my chest to my collar, fingers hooking lightly under the fabric and tugging me an inch closer. The movement didn't force me. It set distance. The shift sharpened my focus. "Look at me," she said.

I already was, but she meant it differently. Not eyes, attention. Presence. I met her gaze fully and let myself feel the discomfort of being seen without trying to manage it.

"Do you think I'm with you because you're safe?" she asked.

The question landed hard because it named a fear I hadn't wanted to speak: that I was the sensible choice, the default, the one she'd settled for. I opened my mouth, then closed it. "Sometimes," I said, and the honesty tasted bitter.

Mara didn't flinch. She nodded slightly, like she'd expected it. "And tonight," she said, "you felt unsafe."

"Yes," I said.

Her thumb moved to the side of my neck and rested over my pulse. "Do you know what I actually want?" she asked, low and steady.

I shook my head.

"I want you to trust me," she said. "Not because you have no fear, but because you can hold fear without turning it into control. I want you to want me, yes, but I want you to want me like a person, not like a prize."

My jaw tightened with the effort of taking that in without turning it into an argument. "I'm trying," I said.

"I know," Mara replied. "But trying isn't doing."

She stepped back and gestured toward the living room. "Come sit."

I followed her to the couch. Mara sat angled toward me, one leg tucked under, posture relaxed but attentive. I sat facing her, knees close enough to feel the heat between them.

For a moment we only looked at each other. The leftover cups and plates around us looked absurd, props from a scene that hadn't ended so much as changed shape. Mara picked up a stray napkin from the cushion, folded it, and set it on the coffee table with precision, the small act reminding me how she controlled environments when she couldn't control people.

"You said you wanted me to look at you the way I looked at him," she said.

Heat rose in my face. "Yeah."

Mara studied me. "Do you know what that look was?"

I hesitated. "Interest," I said. "Amusement."

"It was assessment," Mara corrected. "I was measuring what he wanted and what he was willing to risk to get it."

My stomach dropped and tightened in a different way. "And what did you conclude?"

Mara leaned closer, voice lowering. "That he'll risk very little," she said. "He wants attention without consequences."

"And me?" The word came out too fast.

Her hand slid onto my thigh, firm, fingers splayed, a grounding contact that changed my breathing. "You," she said, "risk yourself. You risk being seen. That's why he bothers you."

The compliment didn't inflate me. It exposed me. I kept my eyes on hers and felt the knot in my chest loosen, not because the problem disappeared, because she'd named something I couldn't say without turning it into an excuse.

Her thumb moved slowly over my thigh. Intimate, controlled. No hurry. No mercy.

"Do you still feel like you need me to prove something?" she asked.

"I don't know," I admitted. "Part of me does."

Mara nodded, unoffended. "Then we're not done," she said.

The words should have sounded like reassurance. They didn't. They sounded like a door closing.

I shifted forward, drawn by the steadiness in her voice, the certainty in her gaze, and Mara raised a finger and pressed it lightly to my mouth, stopping me before I could kiss her.

"Not yet," she said.

I froze, breath shallow, and nodded, because the restraint itself was part of what she was taking from me.

She lowered her hand. "Tell me what you want. Clearly."

I didn't reach for cleverness. "I want you," I said. "I want your attention. I want you to choose me on purpose."

Mara's eyes softened, then sharpened again, as if softness was a choice and she wasn't giving it away for free. "Good," she said. "Now let me."

She shifted closer until our knees touched, contact quiet but absolute, and the rest of the apartment fell away. Her hand stayed on my thigh like an anchor, while her other hand traced the edge of my jaw slowly, as if she were reminding me of my own shape.

"You're still thinking," she murmured.

"I don't know how not to," I admitted.

"Then think about this," Mara said, and leaned in until her breath touched my mouth without the kiss. "Owen wanted a reaction. He didn't get it. He wanted you to break. You didn't. But you're not finished with the feeling, are you?"

"No," I said.

Mara's mouth curved slightly. "I know."

She kissed me then, slow and deliberate, and pulled back before it could turn into escape. "Stay," she whispered.

"I am," I said, voice rough.

“Good,” Mara said, and the word didn’t soothe. It claimed.

I waited for the moment to soften, for the edges to settle into something clean. It didn’t. The apartment stayed too quiet. The mess stayed visible. Owen’s last line stayed lodged under my skin like a splinter I couldn’t reach.

Mara looked past me toward the front door, as if she expected it to click again. When she looked back, her eyes were bright with something that wasn’t comfort.

“If he comes back,” I said, “what happens?”

Mara didn’t answer right away. The pause was a choice.

Then she said, “If he comes back, you don’t get to pretend you’re above this.”

My throat tightened. “And you?”

Mara’s gaze held mine. “I don’t get recruited into your fear,” she said. “And you don’t get to use me as proof.”

The words landed cold and clean. There was no neat ending inside them, no relief. Just a boundary drawn in a room that still smelled like lime and wine and other people.

Mara stood, turning away from me, and began stacking plates again, reclaiming the apartment with silent precision. She didn’t look back as she spoke.

“Go to bed,” she said.

It wasn’t an invitation. It wasn’t tenderness. It was instruction, and it made the air between us feel sharper than it had all night.

I stood there for a second too long, watching her shoulders move with the rhythm of cleanup, watching the steadiness that had been safety and now felt like distance. The front door stayed closed. The building stayed quiet. The night outside went on, indifferent.

I went down the hallway alone. Behind me, I heard the clink of glass in the sink, steady and methodical, like a metronome counting down to something that wasn’t resolution.

Chapter 5

I woke up later than I meant to, pale winter light already pushing through the blinds in thin stripes. For a few seconds I couldn't place why my body felt heavy in a way that wasn't just sleep. Then I turned my head and saw Mara on her side, hair fanned across the pillow, one hand resting on my chest like she'd left it there on purpose, and last night came back in a rush that tightened my stomach and then loosened it again.

The apartment was quiet in that post-party way, the kind of silence that made ordinary sounds feel deliberate. The building settling. The faint hum of appliances. I knew the living room still held evidence, cups in the sink, a sticky spot on the rug, the smell of tequila clinging where it shouldn't. In here it felt like we'd shut a door, but not a lock.

Mara's eyes were open when I looked at her. She'd been awake already, watching me wake up. It should've made me self-conscious. It grounded me instead, and then it didn't. There was a steadiness in her face that didn't read as comfort so much as control, the kind she wore when she'd already decided what was true.

"Morning," I said. My voice came out rough.

"Morning," she said back. Her hand stayed where it was, warm and steady. "How do you feel?"

It wasn't small talk. Mara didn't do small talk when something had teeth. I took a breath and went for honesty because pride felt expensive. "A little hungover," I said. "And not done."

Her thumb moved once on my chest, slow, almost lazy. "Not done with what?"

I stared at the ceiling for a beat, then turned back to her. "With last night," I said. "With him in here. With you looking like you were enjoying it."

Mara didn't flinch. She propped herself on an elbow so she could look at me more directly. "I was calm," she said.

"You were calm," I repeated, and the words came out sharper than I meant. "Like none of it mattered."

Her gaze stayed steady. “It mattered,” she said. “Just not in the way you wanted.”

That landed somewhere low and hot. I shifted under her hand, the contact suddenly too loud. “What does that mean,” I asked.

“It means you were watching me like you were waiting for a verdict,” she said. “And I wasn’t giving you one.”

My jaw tightened. “I didn’t ask for a verdict.”

Her mouth curved faintly, not amused so much as certain. “You did,” she said. “Not with words.”

I could feel my pulse under her palm, the way my body gave me away even when my mouth tried not to. “So what,” I said. “This is just how it is now? You get to stay unreadable and I’m supposed to take it.”

Mara’s eyes narrowed a fraction. “You’re not supposed to take anything,” she said. “You’re supposed to notice what you do when you don’t get certainty.”

The calm in her voice should’ve helped. It didn’t. It turned the whole thing into something clinical, and I hated how much I wanted it to stop being clinical. “I noticed,” I said. “I got pulled. I got angry. I wanted to make you shut it down.”

Mara’s thumb traced a slow circle on my chest, almost absent, and I felt it anyway. “Say it cleaner,” she said.

I swallowed. “I wanted you to choose me loudly,” I said.

Silence stretched. Mara’s gaze dropped, briefly, to my mouth, then lifted again. The look did something to me I didn’t want to admit in daylight. “And?” she said.

“And I don’t like that I wanted it,” I said. “I don’t like that he could make me want it.”

Mara held my gaze like she was weighing whether I meant it or whether I was trying to earn my way out of discomfort. “He didn’t make you want it,” she said. “You already wanted it. He just made it visible.”

That hurt in a way that felt true, and my body reacted the way it always did when Mara hit something real. Heat, irritation, focus. I tried to sit up, to put distance between my skin and her hand, and she didn’t stop me. She let me move like she was watching what I’d do when she didn’t manage me.

When I sat up, the sheet slipped to my waist. Mara’s hand stayed on me for one more beat, then slid off, slow enough to register as a choice. She

watched me like she was deciding whether the night was over or simply changing shape.

“What do you want right now?” she asked.

The question sounded simple. It wasn't. I could feel two urges fighting in me, one toward her, one toward control. I chose the one that was honest. “I want you close,” I said. “And I want you to stop looking like he could get to you.”

Mara's mouth tightened slightly, irritation or restraint. “He didn't get to me,” she said. “He got to you.”

I laughed once without humor. “Yeah,” I said. “He did.”

Mara reached up and touched my throat, thumb resting where my pulse jumped. The contact stole a fraction of my breath. “Then look at me,” she said. “Not at him. Not at the story. At me.”

I held her gaze. The air in the room felt thicker, the quiet less restful and more charged. Mara watched my breathing like she could calibrate it with her eyes.

“Do you want him out of our life?” I asked.

Mara didn't answer immediately. The pause was honest, and I hated how much weight it carried. “I want him out of our space,” she said at last. “And I want you to stop turning him into an excuse for what happens in your body.”

“That's not an answer,” I said.

“It's the only one you're getting,” she replied.

The bluntness landed like a slap without the sound. I could feel my pride flare, then fade into something darker. “So you're keeping the door cracked,” I said.

Mara's eyes sharpened. “Don't,” she said, quiet and warning. “Don't make me the villain because you don't like uncertainty.”

“I don't like him,” I said.

“I know,” she said. “And you still invited him into your head all night.”

Before I could respond, my phone buzzed on the nightstand. The sound was small, but my body reacted like it was a hand on a nerve. Mara's eyes flicked to it and then back to me.

“Check it,” she said, calm enough to be dangerous.

I picked up the phone. Owen's name glowed on the screen.

Last night got weird. You good?

The words were casual, but I could hear his smile inside them. I stared at it with my thumb hovering, the old impulse rising fast, either lash out or smooth it over. Mara watched me without speaking, neutral but attentive, like she wanted to see what I did when no one else was watching.

I typed, deleted, typed again, then committed to something plain.

Yeah. It got weird because you kept texting me and pushing. Don't do that again.

I read it once, stripped out the heat I wanted to include, then hit send before I could talk myself out of having a spine. The message disappeared, and I felt the stupid spike of anticipation that came after any boundary, like I was waiting for the world to punish me for having one.

Mara slid out of bed and pulled on a sweatshirt, moving like the moment wasn't fragile. She walked past me toward the door and paused long enough to squeeze my shoulder. "Good," she said quietly.

I followed her into the living room and winced at the aftermath. Empty glasses on the coffee table. Half-finished chips. Coats in a pile. The rug still darker where we'd blotted the spill. The apartment smelled faintly of tequila and citrus and stale bodies. Mara started gathering cups with the efficient focus she used when she wanted to reset a room. I did the same, moving around her without bumping, falling into our familiar domestic choreography, the one that pretended normal could erase residue.

My phone buzzed again before I could set it down.

Dude, I was trying to help. You were tense as hell. I'm not pushing, I'm checking on you.

I felt irritation flare, tight and hot behind my ribs. I kept my breathing steady and looked at Mara instead of disappearing into the screen. She met my eyes, then glanced briefly at the phone, and I could tell she saw the move. Reframe. Minimize. Make me the problem for naming it.

I typed slower.

I'm not interested in "help" that involves you managing me. No more texts like that. If you keep doing it, we're taking a break.

I sent it and set the phone face down on the counter like I was closing a lid. My pulse stayed high, but it didn't spin into panic. It felt like aftershock, like I'd done something irreversible.

Mara wiped the counter with a damp cloth. "How does it feel?" she asked without looking up.

"Like I'm waiting for him to argue me out of it," I said.

“He will try,” Mara said. “That’s the point.”

The bluntness should have steadied me. It made me feel exposed. There was no neat way out, no version where everyone stayed pleasant. Mara wasn’t offering one.

My phone buzzed again. This time I didn’t reach for it immediately. I carried a stack of cups to the sink first, letting myself delay him, letting my body learn a new reflex. When I finally flipped the phone over, Owen’s reply sat there waiting.

Alright. Message received. Didn’t realize it landed like that. Sorry.

The apology was smooth enough to make me suspicious. Mara watched from the corner of my eye, waiting to see if I’d get hooked by relief. I kept it clean.

Thanks. Keep it simple.

I set the phone down and turned back to the sink. Water ran over glass and sounded absurdly calming. I washed while Mara wiped down surfaces behind me. Soap, warm water, the clink of cups, two people doing routine while something sharper stayed under it.

Every so often Mara passed close enough that her hip brushed mine. Casual. Unapologetic. It should have felt like reassurance. It also felt like a reminder that closeness was something she gave, not something I could force.

When the last cup was rinsed, I dried my hands and leaned back against the counter. The apartment already looked better, counters cleared, living room less chaotic, but the residue of the night wasn’t only physical. It lived in my nervous system, in the way I still expected the phone to buzz with some new angle from Owen.

Mara tied up the trash bag and slipped into her boots. “I’m taking this out,” she said. “Don’t pick up anything else he sends unless you want to.”

“I don’t feel calm,” I admitted.

“Good,” Mara said. “Then you’re not lying to yourself.”

She kissed me quickly, present, then stepped into the hallway. The door closed.

The apartment went quiet again, and the quiet didn’t feel earned. It felt like a pause. I stood there listening to her footsteps fade, and I realized how much my steadiness came from having her in the room. The thought didn’t comfort me. It warned me.

My phone stayed silent. I still picked it up, which annoyed me. Blank screen. No notifications. Relief and a thin irritation rose together. I wanted proof, some clean villain line, something I could point to and justify my anger. Silence didn't give me that.

Then it buzzed.

Also, tell Mara I'm sorry if I crossed a line. I didn't mean to disrespect either of you.

I stared at the message. It was careful, broad enough to be harmless, strategic enough to work. It put responsibility on me to relay it, which meant he'd get into our space again through my mouth if I let him.

I didn't answer. I didn't forward it. I set the phone down and stared at the living room like it might show me what the right move looked like.

When Mara came back, cold air clinging to her sweater, she took one look at my face and said, "He texted."

I nodded and handed her the phone.

Mara read the message. Her expression stayed neutral until she finished. "He wants a side channel," she said. "Through you."

"Yeah," I said, and my voice sounded smaller than I meant.

Mara handed the phone back. "You don't pass messages," she said. "Not his, not anyone's."

"What if he keeps trying?" I asked.

Mara looked at me for a long beat, and her calm didn't feel like comfort. It felt like a line being drawn. "Then you find out whether you can hold your boundary when you don't get a happy ending," she said.

My stomach tightened. "And us?"

Mara stepped close and rested her hands lightly at my waist, not hugging, not soothing, just placing herself there like an anchor she wasn't obligated to be. "Us depends on what you do with this," she said quietly. "Not what he does."

I nodded, because there was nothing else to do. The apartment looked cleaner, but it didn't feel clean. The phone sat on the counter, face down, still capable of vibrating. The front door stayed closed, but it didn't feel locked.

Mara turned away and reached for the coffee beans, starting a new pot like routine could overwrite what was still alive in my body. I watched her move, steady and controlled, and felt the old craving rise again, not just for reassurance, for certainty. For something blunt and undeniable.

The kettle clicked on. Mara didn't look back at me.

I stood there in the quiet, waiting for the coffee, waiting for the next buzz, waiting to see which part of me would reach first.

Chapter 6

The rest of Sunday went quiet after the burn-off, not soothing, just slower. Mara ran errands in the afternoon while I stayed home, half-working and half-resetting the apartment. It felt deliberate, like we were trying to prove the night hadn't rearranged anything important. I folded laundry, answered emails I'd been avoiding, took out recycling. I paid attention to how my body felt when I wasn't braced for a vibration. The impulse to check for Owen's name still surfaced in small flashes, and each time it surfaced I forced a breath through my nose and kept my hands busy. By evening the apartment looked like itself again. That should have been relief. It mostly felt like camouflage.

Mara came back around dinner with grocery bags and that calm expression that made me grateful and faintly resentful. She'd moved through the whole situation without needing to show her work, and I'd almost made it into a crisis just by how hard I watched her. We cooked together, nothing fancy, pasta and salad, moving around each other with familiar ease. Our hands brushed at the sink and the spice rack. The contact felt warmer than usual, and it set my nerves humming because it didn't answer anything. It didn't absolve last night. It didn't punish it either. It just existed, and my body responded to it before my mind could decide what it meant.

After dinner we sat on the couch with a movie on low and talked through work, friends, the week ahead. Comforting, plain, life continuing. Right when I started to believe we'd put the weekend somewhere sealed, my phone buzzed again. The reflex hit my chest before I saw the screen, tighten and prepare, like a trained response.

I didn't grab the phone immediately. I let it sit on the coffee table while I finished telling Mara about a meeting on Tuesday. Mara didn't look at the phone first. She looked at me, checking whether I was about to vanish into my own head.

When I picked it up, it wasn't Owen. It was a coworker thread. My body had already reacted anyway. That irritated me more than it should've,

because it meant Owen was still in my system even when he wasn't present. I set the phone down like it was hot.

"False alarm," I said.

Mara nodded, calm, eyes still attentive. "You're keyed up."

"My brain thinks he's always about to show up," I said.

Mara didn't argue with the word always. She shifted slightly so her thigh pressed against mine, not cuddling, not coddling, just contact that made my attention narrow. Her hand came to rest on my leg. Not light. Not hard. Steady enough that my breathing changed on its own.

"Then don't disappear," she said.

The movie kept playing, sound low, and I stared at the dark TV screen like it might give me an answer I liked. She was right. The worst part wasn't the texts. It was the first ten seconds, the spike that turned me into a shadow of myself. "I'll try," I said, and it sounded thin even to me.

Mara's phone buzzed on the cushion beside her. She glanced at the screen and her expression didn't change. She picked it up, read, then looked at me.

"It's him," she said.

Hearing it out loud tightened my chest anyway. She didn't hide the screen. She turned it so I could see.

Hey. Can we talk? I owe you an apology.

Seeing his words on Mara's phone hit differently than seeing them on mine. It stripped away the last comforting idea that this was something happening only inside my head. He was reaching for her directly now. Anticipation didn't cancel the visceral response. My stomach tightened. The old instinct rose, clamp down, say no, shut it off before the uncertainty could start.

I forced a slow breath and kept my voice steady. "What are you going to do?"

Mara watched me for a beat, weighing the question. "I'm going to answer," she said. "Brief."

She typed without flourish, eyes steady, thumb moving like this was just another notification to clear.

Not tonight. You crossed a line. We're keeping distance.

She hit send and set the phone down. She leaned back into the couch as if it hadn't cost her anything. The composure was real. It was practiced. It

made me grateful and jealous in the same breath, jealous that she could be that clean while my skin still remembered every look Owen had given her.

Mara turned the volume up a notch, letting the movie fill the room again. For about thirty seconds it worked. Then her phone buzzed.

She picked it up, read, and her mouth tightened into a line. She angled the screen toward me.

Understood. I'll keep it respectful. I just don't want you thinking I came over with bad intentions.

Of course. Minimize, reframe, insist on his version. He wasn't apologizing. He was laundering himself.

"He wants the last word," Mara said.

"Don't give it to him," I said, and my voice came out too sharp.

Her eyes flicked to my face. I caught myself and softened my tone without pretending I wasn't angry. "No back-and-forth," I said.

Mara set the phone down, face down this time, and didn't touch it. The refusal felt deliberate, a choice not to be pulled onto his timing.

Heat still lived in my body, and I realized how much I wanted to know exactly where Mara was, not because I needed rescuing, but because the absence of information had been the trigger last night. I used what she'd given me earlier, even though it still felt like wearing someone else's words.

"I'm feeling activated," I said. "Tell me where you are."

Mara turned toward me, calm, and didn't tease the phrasing. "I'm annoyed," she said. "I'm not pulled. He doesn't get access."

"And with him," I asked, careful, "there's no interest."

"No," Mara said, firm. "He's not interesting to me the way he wants to be."

My shoulders loosened a notch. The knot didn't disappear, but it stopped tightening on itself. Mara's hand settled on my thigh again, steady pressure that made my attention drop into my body whether I wanted it to or not.

"You're here," she said.

"I'm here," I said back.

Mara kissed me once, quick and grounding, then rested her head against my shoulder. The movie kept playing. Her phone buzzed one more time in the cushion beside us, and neither of us moved. We let it die into silence. The choice not to touch it felt like power, not over Owen, over the reflex he kept trying to trigger.

After a while Mara lifted her head and reached for her phone with the same calm decisiveness, not urgency. “I’m going to look,” she said, and the announcement mattered. Not secrecy. A warning. A claim.

She unlocked the screen, scanned the message, and I saw a faint tightening around her eyes. She angled the phone toward me.

I get it. I’ll back off. Just want you to know I respect you, Mara.

Clean enough to be polite, strategic enough to be irritating. Respect sounded like something he could cash in later.

“Still trying to look good,” Mara said.

“Still trying to control how it’s remembered,” I said.

“We don’t have to correct him,” Mara replied. “We just don’t let him in.”

We sat with the movie continuing, and my nervous system unwound slowly, not because I was suddenly secure, because Mara’s clarity left my mind fewer places to hide. When the flicker of insecurity rose, it was a sensation with edges instead of a story that ran away with itself.

Mara shifted so she could look at me. “You’re watching my face,” she said, not accusing, simply noticing.

“Yeah,” I admitted. “I’m checking.”

“Checking for what?”

“For that look,” I said, and the honesty tightened my throat. “The one that made me feel like I wasn’t in the room with you.”

Mara held my gaze, then nodded once. “Then read this instead.”

Her fingers traced my jaw lightly, and her palm settled against my cheek with quiet firmness. It wasn’t tender in the usual way. It was directive. It made my pulse jump.

“This is me,” she said. “Right here.”

“Thank you,” I said, and this time gratitude didn’t embarrass me because it wasn’t pleading. It was recognition.

My phone buzzed on the coffee table. The spike hit anyway. I picked it up and saw Owen’s name.

Can we please just talk like adults? I don’t want this to be a thing.

The trap was immediate. Boundaries as drama. My response as the problem. I looked at Mara. She looked back, calm expectation, not telling me what to do, waiting to see if I’d hold.

I took a slow breath and typed a short reply.

It is a thing because of how you acted. We’re taking space. Respect that.

I sent it, set the phone down, and felt the aftershock ripple through me without turning into a wave. Mara nodded once.

“That’s solid,” she said.

After that, the room felt quieter, like something had been sealed. Not fixed. Sealed in the sense that we’d acted aligned. Alignment mattered more than any single text.

Mara turned the movie off before it ended. “Come to bed,” she said, not framed like reward or escape, just a decision.

We turned off lights and locked the door. Ordinary motions that felt intimate after a day of holding lines. In the bathroom Mara brushed her teeth, hair pulled back, face bare and calm. I watched her in the mirror and forced myself not to turn her into a symbol. She was Mara. A person who lived with me and still, somehow, chose me.

In bed she curled against me with her arm across my chest, the same placement as the night before. My mind tried to replay Owen’s lines. It tried to put her face beside his voice. Each time I forced my attention back to physical reality. Mara’s warmth. The weight of her arm. The quiet hum of the building.

After a while Mara spoke softly. “He’s going to try again.”

The certainty tightened my stomach. “You think so?”

“Yes,” she said. “He doesn’t like being told no by me. Not cleanly.”

I exhaled. “So what do we do when he tries?”

“The same thing,” Mara said. “We don’t argue. We don’t justify. We don’t perform.”

Her words should have settled me. They didn’t fully. They left me with the uncomfortable truth that this wasn’t going to end just because we wanted it to. It would end when he got bored or found a new target, and neither of those was under our control.

Then my phone buzzed on the nightstand, sharp in the dark. The spike hit immediately. Mara didn’t move. She waited for me.

I picked it up and squinted at the screen. Owen again.

Last message. I’m sorry. I miss you. Can we reset?

Softened, less obviously strategic, more dangerous because it pulled on history. It made me want to smooth it over so I could stop being the guy with a problem.

I stared at the message and felt Mara’s eyes on me, calm and steady, and I understood the choice wasn’t about Owen. It was about which version of

myself I was willing to live in.

I typed one line.

Not right now. Respect our space.

I sent it, set the phone down, and turned back toward Mara. She didn't praise me. She didn't dramatize it. She pressed her lips to my shoulder in a brief kiss that felt like ownership without words, then settled back against me.

"Sleep," she whispered.

I closed my eyes and let the quiet return. It didn't feel like peace. It felt like a pause we'd earned, and a door we'd shut without knowing whether it would hold.

Monday arrived with gray light. Flat. I was grateful for flat because flat meant no spikes. I went to work, sat through meetings, answered emails, acted like I hadn't spent the weekend confronting a part of myself I didn't like. Every so often there was a flash of Owen's grin, the way he'd said If you tell me to, like my boundary only existed if Mara enforced it. Each flash tightened my chest briefly. I breathed and brought myself back.

Mara texted around noon.

How's your head?

I smiled despite myself. The care was simple, and it did something dangerous, it made me want to rely on it. Better. Busy. You?

Fine. Quiet day. He hasn't texted.

He hasn't texted wasn't comfort. It was a lull. I typed Good, then added Thanks for yesterday, and sent it before I could decide it sounded needy.

We're a team.

When I got home, Mara was at the kitchen table with her laptop open, hair up in the same clip. She looked up and her expression softened, and I felt how exhausted I'd been carrying myself all day. I kissed her, quick and familiar. Her hand rested at my waist a second longer than usual. It made my skin tighten and settle at the same time.

"Any texts?" I asked, and hated that it was still part of my reflex.

Mara shook her head. "Nothing," she said. "He's either sulking or planning."

We made dinner, talked about nothing important. Later we sat on the couch with the TV on without watching it. Mara's legs over mine. My hand on her shin, absent and domestic, like a claim that didn't need saying.

Around nine her phone buzzed. The jolt went through me even though it wasn't my phone. Mara picked it up, glanced, and her expression didn't change. She turned the screen toward me.

Can we please just talk for five minutes? I want to apologize like an adult. I don't like being iced out.

I felt irritation rise because of the framing, his discomfort as the injury. Mara read my face and kept her voice calm.

"He's pushing," she said.

"He's negotiating," I replied.

Mara typed without drama. No. We asked for space. Respect it.

She sent it and turned the phone face down. "Done."

The tension stayed in my body and didn't turn into panic. Mara's hand settled on my knee. "You feel that?" she asked quietly. "We didn't move for him."

"Yeah," I said. "We didn't."

Her phone buzzed again. She didn't pick it up. She looked at me, eyebrows slightly raised, asking without words whether we were going to keep holding the line.

"Let it buzz," I said.

It buzzed once more and then went quiet, and the quiet didn't feel clean. It felt like someone had stepped back into shadow.

The next few days held a tense calm, the kind you get after a decision when you wait to see what comes next. Owen didn't blow up. He went silent in a way that felt like a tactic, a pause meant to make us wonder if we'd overreacted. The thought tried to creep in, maybe it had all been misunderstanding. I kept returning to fact. He'd pushed. He'd bypassed. He'd tried to get permission through deniability.

By Thursday I noticed I wasn't checking my phone as often. The reflex still existed. It was weakening. Mara seemed lighter too. She didn't mention Owen unless I did. She lived her day. The normalness mattered because it made it obvious he wasn't the center, and that meant he had less leverage than he thought.

Thursday night we were making dinner when my phone buzzed with an unfamiliar number. Local area code. My body reacted like it was Owen anyway. I stared at the screen a beat too long.

"Answer it or don't," Mara said, knife moving steadily through vegetables. "Don't freeze."

I exhaled and answered. "Hello?"

"Hey," Owen's voice came through immediately. "It's me."

The drop in my stomach was instant. "Why are you calling from a different number?" I asked.

A brief pause. Then a laugh that tried to sound casual. "My phone died," he said. "I'm on a friend's."

Mara looked up, eyes sharp. I gave her a small shake of my head, not asking for help, just letting her see. She didn't move. She didn't step in. She watched, calm, and that calm felt like pressure.

"What do you want?" I asked.

"You're really doing the cold thing," Owen said, half-joking, half-irritated. "I just want to talk like adults."

I felt the anger flare. I kept my voice even. "We set a boundary," I said. "You keep trying to negotiate it."

"I'm not negotiating," Owen said. "I'm trying to fix it. This is stupid."

"It's not stupid," I said. "You crossed a line."

He let out a breath like he was restraining himself. "Okay. Tell me what line, because from my perspective you're acting like I hit on your girlfriend."

The trap was clean. Deny it and sound paranoid. Confirm it and sound possessive. I didn't dodge.

"You were provoking," I said. "You were texting me during my own party. You were making comments aimed at stirring tension. You're doing it now by calling from another number."

His laugh came shorter. "Jesus. You're making me sound like a villain."

"I'm describing what you did," I said.

Silence. I could hear faint traffic on his end, a muffled voice. He was outside, or he wanted me to think he was.

"Okay," Owen said finally, tone shifting softer, more wounded. "I miss you, Eli. We've known each other forever. You really want to throw that away because I sent a couple texts?"

Nostalgia tugged, real and dangerous. Mara's knife paused for half a second. She watched me, steady. I took a slow breath.

"I'm not throwing anything away," I said. "I'm protecting what matters. Right now that means space."

Owen's voice sharpened. "So she's calling the shots."

It hit my pride on purpose. I felt it and didn't give him the satisfaction of seeing it win.

"We're calling the shots," I said.

Owen went quiet, then said, "Alright," tight. "If that's how you want it." Then, softer again, "Tell Mara I'm sorry."

"I'm not your messenger," I said.

Silence stretched. Then: "Fine. Whatever. Later."

The call ended.

I stared at the phone for a second, pulse loud in my ears, then set it on the counter. Mara looked at me over the vegetables, calm and attentive.

"Different number," she said.

"Yeah," I replied. "He thinks he can force his way back in."

"And you didn't let him," Mara said.

"I didn't," I said, surprised by how true it felt.

Mara went back to chopping like the call hadn't earned more space in our kitchen. "Finish dinner," she said.

So I did, hands slightly shaky, steady enough.

Later, when the dishes were done and the lights were low, Mara stood behind me at the sink and pressed her mouth briefly to the back of my neck. The contact sent heat through me that had nothing to do with comfort. It felt like a claim and a warning at the same time.

"You held," she said, quiet.

I turned my head, not fully turning around, caught between wanting her and wanting to understand her. "For now," I said.

Mara's fingers slid along my hip, slow, deliberate. "For now is all you ever get," she murmured.

Her phone sat face down on the counter. Mine sat beside it. Two small rectangles capable of vibrating. The apartment was quiet. I could feel the night outside the windows, the city indifferent, the building steady.

Mara stepped away, leaving her heat behind in my skin. She didn't say goodnight. She didn't say we're okay. She moved through the room with that calm that could mean anything.

I stood alone for a moment, listening for a buzz that didn't come, and realizing how easily my body could be pulled back to the edge even without a sound.

Chapter 7

After that call, the apartment stayed tight. There wasn't a fight between Mara and me. The intrusion left residue, and my body refused to accept "handled" as "over" just because the line went dead. I moved through the rest of dinner on autopilot, stirring sauce, setting plates, answering Mara's small questions with clipped replies that tried to pass for normal. Mara let me be quiet without letting me disappear. She kept the conversation pinned to ordinary things: work updates, a friend's birthday, whether we should replace the living room lamp. The ordinariness was deliberate. A way of declaring home while my nerves insisted on battleground.

After we ate, I washed while Mara dried, our shoulders brushing in the small kitchen. The contact was casual. I felt it like a signal anyway, how it settled my chest without a speech attached. I didn't want reassurance turned into a lecture. I wanted proof we still moved as one unit. Mara seemed to read that, which was comforting and irritating in the same breath. I hated how much I needed her to see me. I hated that she always did.

When the kitchen was clean, we went to the couch. The TV stayed on, but neither of us watched. I leaned back and tried to let my muscles unclench. Mara curled her legs under her and angled toward me, eyes steady. She didn't ask how I felt right away. She waited until I stopped fidgeting, until my breathing slowed, and then she said, "Tell me what that did to you."

I exhaled. "It made me angry," I said. "Not just at him. At myself. Because part of me still wanted to explain. Like if I said it right, he'd understand."

Mara nodded once. "Because you want resolution."

"Yeah," I said. "And he keeps trying to rewrite it."

"He doesn't want resolution," she said. "He wants access."

The words landed heavy and clean. I watched the muted TV light crawl across my hands. "He accused you of calling the shots," I said.

Mara's brows lifted. "Of course he did."

"It got under my skin," I admitted, because pretending it hadn't would've been theater.

Mara leaned in and set her hand on my thigh, steady pressure. “Because you’re sensitive to being seen as weak,” she said. “And he knows it.”

I nodded. “And because part of me worried he was right.”

“Say more,” Mara said.

I swallowed. “Sometimes it feels like you’re the stronger one,” I said. “Like you carry the emotional weight. Like you stay calm while I...” I stopped, because the rest of the sentence felt like handing her a weapon.

Mara didn’t let me step around it. “While you what?”

“While I get reactive,” I said. “While I need more reassurance than I like admitting.”

Mara’s expression softened slightly, not pity. Recognition. “You’re not weak for needing reassurance,” she said. “You’re weak when you pretend you don’t and then punish me for not guessing.”

Heat rose in my face. Not anger. Exposure. I nodded. “Okay.”

Mara kept her hand on my thigh and shifted closer until her knee touched mine. “Here’s what I want you to notice,” she said. “Tonight, when he called, I didn’t take over. I didn’t rescue you. You still handled it.”

My breath came out longer than I expected. “Yeah.”

“That’s strength,” Mara said. “Not the absence of feeling. The ability to act aligned while you’re feeling.”

The phrasing recalibrated something. I sat with it for a beat, then asked, “So what happens next? He isn’t done.”

Mara’s mouth curved faintly, not amused, like she’d already mapped the next moves. “Next he’ll try to get you in person,” she said. “An ‘accidental’ run-in. An invitation you’re supposed to accept because declining would look rude.”

My stomach tightened. “What if he shows up?”

“Then we don’t have a long conversation on the sidewalk,” Mara said. “We don’t let him pull you into a private corner. We keep it short, polite, and closed.”

“And if he tries to pull you aside,” I said, and I hated how fast the question came, how quickly my mind produced worst cases like it was paid by the hour.

Mara’s eyes narrowed slightly and her tone went firm. “I won’t,” she said. “I don’t do private apologies with someone who uses them as leverage.”

The clarity eased something. I nodded. “Okay.”

Mara leaned in and kissed me once, slow and deliberate. It didn't distract. It reset the room around us. When she pulled back, her gaze held mine with that calm certainty that made my internal narratives feel cheap.

"You're not competing with him," she said quietly. "You're building with me."

The truth landed in the most inconvenient place, the part of me that still wanted to win. I swallowed. "Okay," I said again, and it sounded less like agreement and more like surrendering a habit I'd been using to stay upright.

Mara stood and held her hand out. "Come to bed," she said. The invitation carried more than sleep without spelling it out.

I took her hand and followed. My body settled as we moved together, and for the first time since Owen's call it felt possible to keep him out without fighting him, by refusing to orbit him at all.

In the bedroom the light stayed soft and low, quiet without turning secret. Mara closed the door and didn't rush. She never did when she wanted something to land. Warm light caught the edge of her cheekbone. Then she faced me with that steady look that always read as attention with teeth.

"Come here," she said.

I stepped in. She put both hands on my shoulders, thumbs pressing lightly as if checking what I was still carrying there. I was carrying plenty. She worked the tension with quiet insistence, and my breath changed. It was intimate to be handled with that kind of certainty, to be kept in place without being pinned. Her eyes stayed on my face, watching for the moment my mind tried to sprint back to the call, back to Owen's tone.

"Where are you right now?" she asked.

"With you," I said, and I meant it, but the speed of the answer gave it away. Proof offered too quickly.

Mara's mouth curved faintly. "Slow down," she said. "Don't perform."

I exhaled. My shoulders dropped a fraction. "With you," I said again, slower, and the words landed lower in my body.

Mara nodded like she felt the difference. She slid her hands down my arms, found my hands, laced her fingers through mine, and guided me backward until the backs of my knees met the bed.

"Sit," she said.

I sat. She stayed standing for a moment, looking down at me with that calm, assessing focus that had driven me insane in a crowded room. In here

it didn't feel like judgment. It felt like possession without ownership, like she could have me without taking me.

She stepped closer, close enough that our linked hands rested against her waist. She didn't move them. She didn't invite more. She let them exist, and the restraint made my pulse jump harder than contact would have.

"You handled him," she said quietly.

"I handled him," I echoed, and hearing it out loud made it harder to discount.

Mara leaned in until her mouth hovered near my ear. "Say what you're proud of," she murmured.

The request hit a nerve. Pride usually came out of me disguised as humor. I swallowed. "I didn't let him pull me into a fight," I said. "I didn't make you do it for me."

Her breath warmed my skin for a second. "Good," she said.

She kissed my cheek once, slow and deliberate, then straightened and looked at me again. "And what are you still holding?" she asked.

I hesitated. "I'm still mad," I admitted. "That he tried to frame it like you were controlling me."

Mara's eyes narrowed slightly. "And what do you think about that?"

"He wanted my pride," I said. "And for a second, he got it."

Mara's fingers tightened lightly around mine. "And then?"

"And then I remembered we were aligned," I said. "That it wasn't you controlling me. It was us deciding."

Mara's expression softened. She let my hands go and slid her fingertips up my chest in a slow, grounding motion that deepened my breathing. She wasn't soothing me. She was claiming my attention. The touch made the point: the spike could exist without running the room.

She climbed onto the bed in front of me, knees on either side of my thighs, close enough that there was no space left to negotiate, and she held my gaze.

"Stay with me," she said.

"I'm staying," I said, and there was no rush in it.

Mara's mouth curved, satisfied. She kissed me, slow and unhurried, a kiss that refused to become an escape. When she pulled back, her forehead rested against mine, her breath in my mouth.

"Good," she whispered. "Then let him stay outside our life."

I closed my eyes for a second and nodded. In the quiet, her breath against me, her hands steady on my shoulders, the urge to win thinned into something simpler: the urge to build a life that didn't need an audience and didn't need a rival to feel real.

The next morning I woke before my alarm, not jolted, just surfacing into light and quiet. Mara slept beside me, face relaxed, one hand tucked under the pillow. I watched her breathe for a moment and felt a steadiness in my chest that hadn't been there in weeks. It didn't read as a fix. It read as a pause.

I got up quietly and made coffee, moving through the apartment on soft feet. Pale morning light washed the kitchen window. The city looked muted, as if it hadn't decided to wake up yet. I didn't check my phone first, and the restraint registered as a small victory. I poured two mugs anyway, because anticipating her without making it about reassurance felt clean.

When she came in, hair messy, sweatshirt on, she glanced at the second mug and gave me a small, approving look. "Look at you," she said.

"Domestic," I said.

"Competent," she corrected, and the warmth didn't soften the edge.

We talked while we drank. Nothing heavy. The calm made the weekend feel distant, but I didn't let myself rewrite it as over. Forgetting was how patterns returned. Remembering was how boundaries held.

By lunchtime my phone buzzed with a notification from an app I barely used. I glanced without thinking, and my stomach tightened when I saw Owen's name in the preview. It wasn't a text. It was a tag.

I opened it before I could argue myself out of it. A photo: Owen grinning, arm slung around a guy from our college circle, captioned with something breezy about running into old friends. It wasn't about me directly. It didn't need to be. It landed as a signal. He was broadcasting ease, connected, unbothered, still charming, still inside the group. The timing didn't read as coincidence.

Mara caught the pause. "What is it?" she asked.

I turned the phone toward her. "He posted something."

Mara looked at it for a second and shrugged. "He's performing," she said.

"Yeah," I said, but it still hit my pride. The post implied I was the one making things uncomfortable while Owen stayed the fun one with the wide smile. The impulse to defend myself to an invisible jury showed up fast.

Mara set her mug down and looked at me. “This is the part where you want to fix your image,” she said. “Where you want to make it clean for other people.”

I exhaled. “Yeah.”

“You don’t owe them the clean version,” she said. “You owe us consistency.”

The knot eased slightly. “So I ignore it.”

Mara’s mouth curved faintly. “You ignore it.”

I put the phone down and didn’t scroll. The restraint felt like discipline. The thought lingered anyway, sharper now: Owen wasn’t going to stop at messages. He was going to use social space. That was his field. Private channels hadn’t worked, so he widened the frame.

Later that afternoon a message came in from Kyle, someone I hadn’t talked to much since college.

Hey man. Owen said there’s some weird tension. Everything okay?

The triangulation was immediate and obvious. My chest tightened with anger. Owen was recruiting the group to pressure me back into normalcy. I stared at Kyle’s message and felt the urge to write a long explanation, to set the record straight, to control perception.

Mara saw the look on my face and said, “Don’t.”

I took a breath and typed something short.

Everything’s fine. Just taking space right now.

I hit send before I could add more. The reply felt incomplete. It was also enough, and it didn’t hand Owen a story to twist.

Mara watched me set the phone down. “Good,” she said.

Kyle’s message stayed in my head after I answered, not because Kyle’s opinion mattered that much, because it proved Owen had moved up a layer. He wasn’t going to accept a clean boundary quietly. He needed the story to reshape itself into something where he looked reasonable and we looked dramatic. That story would work on some people. Simple versions always did.

Mara watched me chew on it. “You’re thinking about reputation,” she said.

“I’m thinking about how he’s framing it,” I replied.

“Same thing,” she said.

She wasn’t wrong. In my head, the old group still functioned like a court. Owen wanted the crowd. I didn’t want court anymore. I wanted my own

life. Still, stepping out didn't stop the court from existing.

That evening Mara and I went for a walk, partly for groceries, partly because moving outside drained static out of my body. The air was cold and clean. The sidewalks were wet from earlier rain. We walked side by side, shoulders brushing when we passed people on narrow sections. Mara didn't reach for my hand right away. She waited. When I reached for her, she laced her fingers through mine in a way that read as choice, not habit.

Halfway down the block my phone buzzed. I didn't pull it out immediately. I let it buzz and stopped walking long enough to take a breath, because I could feel the spike rising. Mara noticed and squeezed my hand once, steady.

"What is it?" she asked.

I checked. A text from Nina.

Quick heads-up: Owen asked me if you two were okay. I told him to talk to you. Just wanted you to know.

Anger flared, at Owen's persistence, at the way he kept using other people as doors. Under it, a small, grudging appreciation for Nina's response. She'd redirected. She hadn't fed him.

Mara read my face. "Tell me," she said.

I handed her the phone. She read and nodded. "He's collecting temperature readings," she said.

"That's a polite way to say he's stirring," I said.

Mara's mouth curved faintly. "Same thing," she said again, and I exhaled through my nose, almost a laugh.

I texted Nina back. Thanks for telling me. Appreciate you redirecting.

Then I pocketed the phone and kept walking. Mara didn't ask if I was okay in a soothing way. She held my hand and kept our pace steady, like the best response to Owen's orbit was forward motion in a direction he didn't control.

At the grocery store we moved through aisles, made mundane decisions about coffee beans and pasta sauce. The mundanity helped. We paid, walked home with bags cutting into our fingers, and by the time we reached the building my shoulders had loosened.

In the elevator Mara glanced at me in the mirrored wall. "You know what he's trying to do," she said.

"Make it look like we're the problem," I said.

“More than that,” she replied. “He’s trying to make you feel isolated. Like everyone’s checking on you and you’re the one creating tension. That isolation makes you easier to push.”

The clarity hit hard. “So I stay connected,” I said.

Mara nodded. “To me. To your own reality. To people who aren’t playing his game.”

Back in the apartment we put groceries away. Moving around her felt easier now, less scanned, less braced. Owen was still out there. Inside the apartment, the alignment felt stronger, like the walls could hold it.

Later that night, brushing my teeth, my phone buzzed again. This time it was a calendar invite from Kyle: Drinks Friday? Old crew.

My stomach tightened immediately. The shape of the pressure was obvious. Show up and pretend everything is fine, or don’t show and become the problem.

I walked into the bedroom and showed Mara the invite. She read it, face calm.

“What do you want to do?” she asked.

“I don’t want to go,” I said. “Not if he’s there.”

Mara nodded. “Then don’t.”

I stared at the invite and felt optics tug. Prove I wasn’t scared. Prove I wasn’t the insecure boyfriend. Prove I could handle it. Then Mara’s earlier line cut through: consistency over reputation. I clicked decline and typed a short note.

Can’t make it. Have plans.

It wasn’t a lie. The plan was to protect my peace.

Mara watched me send it. “Good,” she said.

The word kept landing the same way, and the repetition started to feel like a new habit replacing an old one.

Declining the invite should’ve been pure relief. It was relief with a thread of anxiety braided through it, the worry that I’d just proved Owen’s narrative by not showing up. I went to bed with that thread humming faintly and woke with it still there, smaller but persistent. At work I kept moving, meetings, emails, tasks, and every gap tried to fill with the same reflex: who thinks what, who heard what, who Owen talked to. It was exhausting because it had no end point, and my mind still kept reaching for one.

Around midday Owen didn’t text. He posted again. A story video, him at some coffee shop, laughing with Kyle and another guy from college,

captioned with an inside joke I recognized. It didn't name me. It didn't have to. The message was absence: the group still exists, the fun still exists, and I'm not there.

When I got home Mara was cooking, music low, the apartment warm and smelling like garlic. She looked up and read my face immediately.

"He did something," she said.

I handed her my phone with the story paused.

Mara watched for a few seconds, expression flat. "He's baiting," she said, and handed it back like it was an ad.

"It's working," I admitted. "I hate that it's working."

Mara stirred, calm. "It's working because you're still letting him define what winning looks like," she said.

Frustration tightened my chest. "So I'm supposed to not care what people think?"

"You can care," she said, glancing over her shoulder. "You just can't let it drive." She turned off the burner and faced me. "Tell me what you're afraid of."

I swallowed. The fear was simple and humiliating. "That everyone will think I'm insecure," I said. "That I couldn't handle him. That I'm the guy who got territorial."

Mara nodded slowly. "And if they do, what happens?"

"Nothing," I admitted. "My life doesn't fall apart. It just feels humiliating."

Mara stepped in and put her hand on my chest. "Humiliation is an emotion," she said. "Not a verdict."

My breathing slowed. "So how do I stop caring?"

"You don't stop caring," she said. "You stop outsourcing your self-respect to a group chat. You know what happened. I know what happened. That has to be enough."

I nodded, and the truth held even while my ego resisted it.

Mara watched me for a beat, then said, "Do you want to see Kyle? Just you and him. No Owen."

I blinked. "Why?"

"Because you shouldn't have to disappear from your friendships to hold a boundary," she said. "You also don't have to step into Owen's staging. Choose a version that's ours."

The logic landed clean. My earlier refusal hadn't been choice. It had been defense. Avoiding the group made Owen's story easier. Connection on my terms didn't.

I texted Kyle. Down to grab a drink sometime, just us?

Kyle responded a few minutes later. Tomorrow?

Relief hit first. Then dread, quieter and sharper. I'd have to show up without Mara beside me and hold my boundary in a social setting where old roles still had gravity.

Mara read it in my face. "You can do it," she said. "Not by being tough. By being clear."

I nodded. "Okay."

The next afternoon I walked to the bar Kyle picked, a place near his office that tried hard to look casual while charging too much for beer. The air outside was cold enough to sting my cheeks, and the sting helped because it kept me in my body. As I walked I repeated the only goals that mattered: stay present, stay clear, don't debate. I wasn't going to convince Kyle. I was going to show up and see what was there.

Kyle sat at a high-top near the window. He stood when he saw me and clapped my shoulder with that loud friendliness people used when they wanted everything to be simple.

We ordered beers. For ten minutes it stayed normal, work, weather, the ritual of two men pretending life ran on uncomplicated rails. My shoulders dropped in small increments. Then Kyle leaned back, took a sip, and said, "So."

The word carried weight without admitting it.

I felt my chest tighten and kept my face neutral. "So," I echoed.

Kyle scratched his jaw, eyes on his glass. "Owen said you were upset," he said. "He made it sound like there was a misunderstanding."

Facts, not feelings. I took a slow breath. "It wasn't a misunderstanding," I said. "He crossed lines at my place. We asked for space. He's been trying to negotiate it."

Kyle frowned. "What lines?"

"He texted me during the party," I said. "Telling me to relax. Saying I was making it obvious. Comments meant to stir tension. Then he wouldn't drop it afterward."

Kyle's eyebrows jumped. "He texted you during your party?"

"Yeah," I said. "And he kept doing it after we told him to stop."

Kyle exhaled and leaned back. "That's not great."

"No," I said. "It isn't."

Kyle took another sip. "He said you thought he was hitting on Mara."

The old spike hit. I kept my voice steady. "He was being inappropriate," I said. "Call it flirting or not, it was designed to create tension. Mara and I are solid. We just don't want him in our space right now."

Kyle studied me like he was checking whether I was about to blow up. When I didn't, he nodded slowly. "Okay," he said. "That's fair."

"I'm not asking you to pick sides," I added. "I'm asking you not to be a messenger."

Kyle held up a hand. "Yeah. I get it," he said. "Owen can be a lot."

We let the silence sit. The difference between debate and clarity was obvious in my body; clarity cost less. After another round the conversation drifted into other topics, and the normal talk felt more genuine because it wasn't built on pretense.

When we stood to leave Kyle clapped my shoulder again, lighter. "Text me," he said. "We'll do this again."

"Yeah," I said. "We will."

On the walk home my phone buzzed. My body reacted automatically. I checked and saw Owen's name.

So you met Kyle. Nice.

My stomach tightened. Surveillance, or performance of surveillance. Either way it was the same move: reclaim space through implication.

I didn't respond. Not because I had nothing to say. Because responding would put me back inside his game. I pocketed the phone and kept walking through the cold air, letting the sting on my cheeks keep me where I was.

When I got home Mara sat on the couch reading. She looked up as I came in and read my face immediately.

"How was it?" she asked.

"Good," I said, surprised by how true it felt. "I was clear. He got it."

Mara's eyes softened slightly. "And Owen?"

I showed her the message. She read it and shook her head once. "Of course," she said.

"I didn't answer," I said.

Mara stood, crossed the room, and set her hands lightly at my waist. The contact made my breath catch, not because it was sweet, because it was precise. She knew what it did to me and she used it anyway.

“That’s you choosing,” she said quietly.

I exhaled and felt the day settle. “Yeah,” I said. “It is.”

For the first time since the party, forward motion felt real, not because Owen stopped, because I did. And still, later, when the apartment went quiet and Mara fell asleep with her leg hooked over mine, I lay awake listening to the building hum and waiting for my phone to buzz. Not expecting it. Wanting it and hating myself for wanting it, as if some part of me needed proof that the door was still there to keep my hand on the lock.

Chapter 8

I thought talking to Kyle would buy me relief, like pulling out a thorn and walking like nothing happened. It did not. The anxiety did not fade. It learned rhythm. It stopped buzzing in the background and started arriving on schedule: my phone lighting up, a social post, an unfamiliar number, Mara going briefly unreadable when she was thinking. Predictable was an improvement. It still meant my body treated social pressure like a threat.

The following Tuesday, Owen made his next move.

No text. No call. An email to my work address, subject line dressed up as professionalism: Quick reset.

I sat at my desk, coffee cooling beside the keyboard, and stared at the preview like delaying would change the words. When I opened it, it was exactly what I expected and still infuriating in how clean it was. Miscommunication. Friendship. I value our history. Then the line that tightened my jaw: I don't want personal stuff affecting the wider group.

The wider group. As if he ran it. As if my boundary was an inconvenience he could manage.

I did not reply. I forwarded it to my personal email so I could show Mara later, then archived it. Owen had picked email for a reason. Email looked serious. Email implied I owed him something.

By the time I got home, my shoulders were up by my ears. Mara was in the kitchen chopping vegetables, hair pinned up, face calm. She looked at me the second I walked in.

"He did something," she said.

"Email," I said, and it sounded absurd out loud.

Her eyebrows lifted. "Work email?"

"Yeah." I handed her my phone with the forwarded message open.

She read quickly, then let out a small breath that held no surprise. "He's escalating optics."

"It reads like he wants a paper trail."

"He wants leverage," she said. "Paper trails help."

A laugh tried to come out and died on the way. "What do we do?"

“Nothing,” Mara said, handing the phone back. “You already told him. He’s choosing not to accept it. You do not owe him a new explanation in a different format.”

I felt the urge anyway, the old sickness of trying to draft the perfect response. Not to fix him, to control how I looked while he twisted the room around me. Mara saw it before I spoke.

“You want to respond because you want control,” she said.

“Yeah.”

Mara stepped closer and put her palm on my chest, steady pressure, not soothing, pinning my attention where she wanted it. Her touch made my breath hitch in a way I hated admitting. The heat moved fast under my skin, the kind that always showed up when she did something simple and certain.

“Then do the thing,” she said.

“I’m activated,” I said. “I want to prove I’m not the problem.”

Mara held my gaze like she could see the part of me that wanted to bend. “You do not have to prove anything to someone who benefits from you trying.”

Then my phone lit up again. An unfamiliar local number. My body reacted like it was Owen before I even looked.

I let it ring.

Mara watched, expression unreadable in a way that made my stomach tighten, then it went to voicemail and she said, “If it’s him, you block the number.”

I looked at her. The simplicity irritated me because it gave him no stage.

“Not as punishment,” she added. “As hygiene.”

Hygiene. Not drama. Not victory. Just removal.

I checked the transcription. One line: “Hey, it’s Owen. Call me back when you can.”

The old reflex surged: engage, explain, be reasonable, make it end. Mara did not steer me. She waited.

I blocked the number.

Then I set the phone down and exhaled. The quiet shock came from how final it was. No argument. No reframing. No access.

Mara’s mouth curved faintly. “Good.”

For the first time in a week, my nervous system registered a new signal. Not that Owen had stopped, that I could.

Blocking the number did not feel like closure. It felt like the moment after a loud sound ends, silence with vibration still inside it. I stood in the kitchen with my phone face down on the counter, palms braced on either side, and noticed how much energy I had spent staying available. Not replying, being ready. Expecting I would have to deal with him at any moment. Blocking did not erase him. It shut one channel cleanly, and my body felt the absence like a missing tooth.

Mara went back to her vegetables like blocking a number belonged in the same category as taking out the trash. The calm made the boundary feel ordinary, which should have helped more than it did. I hovered, then joined her at the sink, rinsing greens. Cold water ran over my hands, steady and physical, a way out of my head.

“You’re quieter,” Mara said.

“I’m listening.”

“To what?”

I exhaled. “To see if I feel guilty. Part of me thinks blocking him is mean.”

Mara’s knife paused for a beat, then kept moving. “Mean is a story. What’s the function.”

Function. Not morality. Mechanism.

“It stops him from reaching me.”

“And why do you want that.”

“Because he doesn’t respect boundaries,” I said. “Because he escalates. Because every time he reaches out I get pulled into managing his feelings and his narrative.”

Mara nodded once. “So blocking isn’t mean. It’s accurate.”

Accurate soothed in a way kindness never did. I rinsed the greens again, then asked the question my mind would not stop circling.

“What if he shows up in person.”

Mara did not blink. “Then we deal with the person, not the fear.”

“How.”

She set the knife down and met my gaze. “Short. Polite. Closed. If he shows up at the building, he does not come in. If he shows up at a bar, we do not step outside to talk privately. If he creates a scene, we leave.”

I nodded. “And if he tries to talk to you alone,” I said, too fast, like the fear had been waiting behind my teeth.

“He won’t,” Mara said. “And if he tries, I say no.”

We finished cooking, ate, let the evening move along in something like normal. Under it, I still expected him to reroute. People like Owen did not stop. They looked for another door.

On Friday he proved me right.

An email from Nina.

Subject: FYI

Body: Owen asked me if he can come by your place to “apologize in person.” I told him I’m not getting involved. Just letting you know.

Come by your place. The words tightened my skin. It was not only audacity. It was a test. Would the lobby become his stage.

I forwarded Nina’s email to Mara and wrote one line: He’s trying to come here.

Mara replied within minutes: Not happening. I’ll handle if he contacts me. Don’t engage.

The directness steadied me and made my body want her at the same time, want her decision like I wanted her hand on my chest. It was the same hunger in a different suit. I did not like the fact my nervous system confused control and comfort.

That night we stayed in, ordered takeout, kept the lights low. I tried to relax. Around ten, the building intercom buzzed. The sound cut through the apartment, sharp and wrong, and my heart jumped.

Mara looked at me. “Don’t move yet.”

The intercom buzzed again.

I walked to the panel and pressed the button without opening anything. “Yeah?” I said, voice even.

A pause, then Owen’s voice, distorted through the speaker. “Hey, it’s Owen. Can you buzz me up? I just want to talk.”

Heat rose in my chest. The plan dropped over it like a lid. Short. Polite. Closed.

“No,” I said. “This isn’t a good time. Please leave.”

He laughed lightly, as if I had played along. “Come on. Five minutes.”

“No,” I repeated. “Leave.”

A beat. Then, “Mara home?”

The spike hit sharp. I did not give him her name as a doorway.

“Leave,” I said. “Now.”

Silence. Then, edged and quieter: “This is ridiculous.”

I did not argue. I did not justify. “Goodnight,” I said, and released the button.

The intercom buzzed a third time.

Mara stepped beside me and put her hand on my forearm, steady pressure. Her touch was a warning and a claim. It made my breath catch. It also kept me from doing something stupid.

“Don’t answer,” she said.

We let it buzz until it stopped. The apartment went quiet again, but the quiet felt strained, like the hallway was listening back.

Mara turned to me. “You did it.”

“He came here,” I said. Disbelief and anger fought for space.

“Yes,” Mara said. “And he didn’t get in.”

My limbs still carried adrenaline. I leaned my head back against the wall and closed my eyes.

Mara kissed my temple. “Stay with me,” she whispered.

I opened my eyes. “I’m here.”

For the first time, the boundary did not feel like a line in a conversation. It felt like a door we kept shut.

We did not hear him leave. That made the silence heavier. My mind kept placing him in the lobby, checking his phone, recalculating, deciding whether to push again. The image pricked my skin. Mara’s hand stayed on my forearm, warm and steady, holding me in what was real. After a minute she said, “Come away from the door,” like she could see the guard post forming in me.

We went back to the living room and sat on the couch without turning the TV on. The apartment felt exposed in a new way. Not unsafe, violated. Owen’s voice stayed in my head, casual and entitled, like access was a right because he had decided he needed closure.

Mara looked at me. “Talk.”

“I’m furious,” I said. “He showed up at our building. After all that.”

Mara nodded. “That’s escalation.”

“I want to go down there,” I admitted. “I want to tell him off in person.”

“That would feel good,” Mara said, “and it would give him what he wants.”

“I know.”

“Look at me,” she said.

I met her gaze. The steadiness in it cut through my anger in a way that was almost erotic, not soft, not tender, exact. She was not asking. She was taking my attention and I let her because it felt better than the chaos did.

“He wanted you in a hallway,” she said quietly. “Face to face. So he could perform remorse or provoke anger, maybe both. You didn’t give him a stage.”

I nodded. “What if he doesn’t leave. What if he waits.”

Mara did not flinch. “Then we call the building manager. Or security. If it becomes necessary, the police. He doesn’t get to use persistence as a weapon.”

The practicality startled me because it was clean. No debate. No wrestling with what it meant. Just protocol.

My phone buzzed and my body spiked anyway. I had blocked his number, it was not him. It was Nina.

Did he come by? He just texted me “I’m going to fix this tonight.”

The cold drop hit my stomach. I showed Mara.

She read it and said, “Okay,” like she was switching gears. “We document.”

“Document how.”

Mara took my phone and typed back to Nina, short and flat: Yes, he tried to come up. We told him to leave. If he contacts you again, don’t engage.

She handed the phone back. “Screenshot what you can. If there’s an intercom log, get it. If not, write down the time.”

I read the microwave clock out loud. Mara repeated it and typed it into a note with the date. The act felt strange, like treating Owen like a stranger. Then the logic caught up. He had chosen to act like one.

We sat for another ten minutes, listening. Nothing. Finally Mara said, “He’s gone,” not as certainty, as decision. “Even if he isn’t, we’re not guarding.”

She drew the blinds, checked the lock, then turned to me. “Bed.”

In the bedroom the quiet stayed heavy. I lay with my eyes open, listening for the elevator, the intercom, anything. Mara curled against me and put her hand on my chest. Her breathing slowed on purpose, a steady rhythm inviting mine to match. Her palm warmed me, and the warmth did not resolve anything. It made the waiting sharper. It made my body want her while my mind kept picturing him in the lobby.

“He doesn’t get to move into your body,” she whispered.

“He already did,” I said.

“Not permanently,” Mara said. “Not if you notice and release.”

I tried. I breathed out and let my jaw unclench by degrees. Mara’s hand stayed steady, not rescuing, reminding. Sleep came in uneven waves and then it took me.

In the morning I checked my phone first anyway and hated myself for it. No new texts. No emails. No calls. The silence felt suspicious. It was also relief.

Over coffee, Mara said, “He crossed a line. So we tighten the boundary.”

“How.”

“We tell the group,” Mara said. “Facts. He showed up uninvited after being asked for space. People stop relaying messages.”

My stomach tightened at the idea. The optics. The risk of looking dramatic. Mara saw it and did not soothe me.

“You don’t want to,” she said.

“It feels like escalating.”

“He escalated,” Mara said. “We make reality visible so he can’t hide inside confusion.”

We drafted the message at the kitchen table the way you draft something that could become evidence. Short. Clean. Defensible. I kept drifting toward context, the careful tone that would stop anyone from thinking I was overreacting. Mara cut it down every time.

“Facts,” she said. “Boundary. Request. Done.”

Typing into the group chat felt like stepping onto a stage I did not want. The purpose was not performance. It was containment. Reduce confusion. Cut off messengers. Shrink the room he kept trying to work.

I sent it.

For a minute nothing happened. Then Nina replied: Thanks for saying it. I won’t relay anything.

Kyle: Got it. Sorry he did that.

A couple others: Understood. That’s not okay.

The simplicity loosened my chest. Then Owen replied.

I’m shocked you’d put this in the group like I’m some kind of threat. I came to apologize. Eli wouldn’t even talk to me. This is being blown way out of proportion.

My pulse jumped. A dozen replies formed instantly, corrections, receipts, the sharp sentences designed to make him feel exposed. The urge to win

surged.

Mara read it and said, “No response.”

“He’s lying.”

“I know,” Mara said. “And you don’t need to correct every lie. You needed the record. You have it.”

Owen kept typing.

Also I didn’t “show up uninvited.” I buzzed. That’s a normal thing friends do. This is insane.

Then:

Mara, if you have an issue with me, say it to me. Don’t hide behind Eli’s paranoia.

My stomach dropped and heat rushed my face. The move was familiar. Isolate me, label me unstable, dare Mara to break alignment in public. I waited for her to cut him down. I waited for her to defend me. I waited for her to make the room safe.

Mara’s expression barely changed. She typed one line.

Owen, stop. You’ve been asked for space. Respect it.

She sent it, then muted the chat. No argument. No explanation. Just a door closing.

Owen replied almost immediately: Wow. Okay. Message received.

Then silence.

Adrenaline drained in slow waves. Mara poured coffee like the exchange had not earned a crisis. She turned to me. “That’s it.”

“I didn’t think it would be that simple,” I admitted.

“It’s not simple,” Mara said. “It’s final.”

The word sat wrong in my chest. Final should have felt safe. It felt like the edge of something.

We kept living, and at first it took effort. Work. Errands. Groceries. Dinner on the couch. Quiet days with no new explosions. The calm started to feel like distance actually holding. Owen had been loud because he had access. With access cut, he had less leverage. The group message made it harder to use messengers without people noticing.

I did not trust the calm. I waited for a new channel, a new number, a fake account, a surprise appearance. My body did not learn door closed instantly. It listened for knocks that did not come. Mara noticed the small tells, the way I looked up when the elevator stopped on our floor, the way my eyes flicked to the intercom panel when it buzzed for deliveries.

About a week after the group message, Mara took my hands in the kitchen.

“We recalibrate,” she said.

“How.”

“By making him boring,” she said.

The phrasing made me blink. “What does that mean.”

“It means we stop treating him like the center,” she said. “No scanning. No reading into posts. No using his name as shorthand for your anxiety.”

I exhaled. “Easy to say.”

“Yes,” Mara said. “That’s why it’s practice.”

We treated it like training. When I felt the urge to check the chat, I named it. Mara would nod and point me at something physical. Walk. Shower. Push-ups. The urge passed. Over time, it passed faster. It did not disappear. It loosened.

Then, on a Thursday while Mara was out, the intercom buzzed. The sound cut through the apartment and my body reacted instantly. I stood still for a beat, breathed, walked to the panel and pressed the button without letting anyone in.

“Yeah?”

A woman’s voice: “Delivery for 1207.”

Relief hit so fast it almost made me dizzy. I buzzed her up, took the package, then stood in the hallway after she left, noticing how my body stayed braced like it had escaped something. I dropped to the floor and did push-ups until my arms burned lightly. It did not solve anything. It pulled me out of story and into muscle.

When Mara got home, I told her. She nodded.

“Good.”

No softness. No celebration. Just a note on the ledger.

Early Saturday morning, Mara’s phone buzzed on the nightstand. The vibration woke me and the spike hit before I was fully conscious. Mara reached for the phone, read, and her face stayed calm. She turned to me.

“He’s trying again.”

She angled the phone so I could see. From an unknown number: Mara, I’m in a bad place. I need to talk. Please.

The tactic shift was immediate, offended to vulnerable, angry to needy. Designed to bypass boundaries by invoking guilt. My stomach tightened because guilt had trained me like a reflex.

Mara stared at the screen for a beat. “He’s manipulating.”

I nodded, and the question still came anyway, unwelcome. “What if he actually is.”

Mara looked at me, steady. “If he’s in danger, he calls emergency services. He calls a crisis line. He calls family. He doesn’t get to use you as a therapist, and he doesn’t get to use me as a rescue.”

She put her palm on my chest, the same pressure that always anchored me, the same pressure that always made my body respond too fast. “Stay,” she said.

“I’m staying.”

Mara typed one line, showed it to me, then sent it.

If you’re in danger, call 911 or a crisis line. We’re not available. Please stop contacting me.

She blocked the number and set the phone down. Her face stayed composed, but the air between us changed. Not calmer. Sharper. Like something had been cut and the cut was clean and still bleeding.

“He’ll be angry,” I said quietly.

Mara’s mouth curved faintly. “He’ll survive.”

The message sat between us afterward, not because we needed to talk, because it clarified what Owen would do when he didn’t get his way. Charm. Offense. Social pressure. Now crisis. Each move tried to make the boundary look like cruelty. Watching Mara block him without flinching hit two nerves at once: relief, because she stayed firm, and a dull ache, because some part of me still wanted to be kind enough to fix it.

Mara lay on her back and stared at the ceiling, breath even. Irritation sat at the corners of her mouth like a restraint.

“You okay?” I asked.

“Yes,” she said. “Annoyed.”

My anxiety shifted. Less about Owen, more about what comes next. “Do you think he’ll stop.”

“Not immediately,” Mara said. “But he’s running out of moves that don’t make him look worse.”

It made sense. My body did not trust sense. It trusted patterns.

Later, Nina texted. Owen messaged me again. Says you two are being cruel.

Kyle called. Owen’s been intense. He’s telling people you and Mara are overreacting.

Each one felt like a hand reaching under the door.

Mara stayed steady through it, but her steadiness did not wrap around me like a blanket anymore. It pressed in. It demanded I hold myself. The intimacy shifted. Less soothing, more sharpened. Her hand on my chest at night felt like an anchor and a warning. A reminder of where I belonged, and what I could lose if I got pulled apart.

Two days later, the building manager called. Procedural. Owen had been seen outside the lobby again, hovering. Security asked him to leave; he did. No scene. The manager's voice stayed firm: If he returns, we'll proceed with trespassing.

Trespassing was an ugly word. Clarifying, too. It meant the world was starting to treat him the way he had earned. It also meant this was not over. People did not hover outside buildings for closure. They hovered for access.

Mara and I did not celebrate. We went out to dinner because she refused to let our life become a perimeter. We talked about work, a spring trip, whether we wanted to move when the lease ended. Normal things. Real things. Her phone buzzed once. She checked, expression unchanged, set it down.

"Spam," she said.

I watched her face anyway. I tried not to read. I tried not to ask. The fear sat there, patient, like it had moved in.

At home, I washed dishes while Mara dried. She stepped close at one point, brushed her hip against mine, and heat moved through me without relief. It felt like a claim. It felt like a dare. It felt like she was reminding me that home had a cost, and the cost was control I could not outsource to her.

In bed, Mara curled against me and put her hand on my chest. The contact grounded me. It also held me in place.

"I'm sorry," I said into the dark.

"For what," Mara asked.

"For how long it took me," I said. "To stop making you prove things."

Mara's voice stayed calm. "You saw it," she said. "You acted. That's what matters."

I swallowed. "I'm done letting someone else write our story."

Her fingers pressed once. "Then keep doing it," she said. "Quietly."

I closed my eyes and tried to let my body settle. The apartment was quiet, but the quiet did not feel like peace. It felt like a pause. A held breath. Somewhere out there, Owen was still a person with a name in our

building's system and a reason to keep trying, even if that reason was only spite.

In the morning, sunlight cut through the blinds in thin stripes. Mara's hand still rested on my chest. I did not reach for my phone. I lay there listening to the building, waiting for the elevator, waiting for the intercom, waiting for the next angle. Mara breathed steadily beside me, and for a moment the steadiness almost felt like safety.

Almost.

Then a muffled sound came from the hallway, a door somewhere down the corridor closing a little too hard, and my body tightened before my mind caught up. Mara did not move. Her hand stayed on my chest, heavy and possessive, holding me in place while my attention strained toward the world outside our door.

I lay there in the stripes of light and realized something I did not want to admit: the boundary held, but it did not make me feel free. It made me feel watched. It made me feel like the next move would not be his call, or mine, but the building's, security's, the police's, a clean chain of escalation that would leave marks.

Mara's fingers pressed once more, not comfort, instruction.

"Stay," she murmured.

I stayed. I listened anyway.